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Players and Empire

Groundwork for an epistemology in Game Studies

MASTER THESIS

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Acknowledgements

Tout ceux que nous avons aimés, détestés, connus ou seulement entrevus parlent par notre voix.

All those we have loved, detested, known, or simply glimpsed speak through our voice.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty 1960.

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Introduction: Explanation of an Explanation

The present master's thesis is written in a time of increased democratic crises (Niosi 2023) and crimes against humanity (United Nations 2024a) like in Palestine (United Nations 2024b) and Ukraine (United Nations 2022), and their representation is broadcast in news media combined with political inaction seems to normalise them more than raising awareness. The events are real and tragic, but information reaches the privileged countries as if it were a dystopian fiction. The age of post-truth (cf. Glattfelder 2019) casts doubt on the ability of imperialist powers to learn from history, i.e., to inscribe themselves in the history of humanity so as not to repeat mistakes, without even having to look outside Western countries since the experience of Nazism in Europe, the application of colonialism within Europe (Césaire 1955, 88). Exploitation outside the West has reached its limits and is turning in on itself, after a series of massive tragedies linked to the colonisation of the 21st century, to which the 5.4 million deaths in the Congo between 1998 and 2007 (Coghlan et al. 2007, ii) are added to the colonial massacres of the 19th century in this same country (M'Bokolo 2003). Next to this violence, the managerial methods that started during the Nazi's regime (Chapoutot 2020) persisted through the extreme centrist neoliberalism, a political tendency that historically already gave power to the Nazis (Chapoutot 2025). The power structures of neoliberalism and their control over people's lives can be traced back to the 19th century (cf Foucault 2004). The 19th century saw the emergence of the medical model as a way of integrating human suffering into the reason for empire, symbolically desecrating cemeteries for reasons of hygiene (Tinková 2020, np). To these phenomena of colonial mass murder, and the loss of meaning through the Empire's rationalisation of human suffering, are added mechanisms of marginalisation embodied in disciplinary and normative institutions (cf. Foucault 1972; 1975; 1999).

The post-war *Trente Glorieuses*—a term coined and subtitled an “invisible revolution” by Fourastié (1979)—that enabled localised, particularly in France, waves of social progress, full employment and decolonization, because the army had been weakened an echo of the conditions of the Third Republic: the country had to be weakened by years of war so its people were to have the strength to change it (Houte 2014) without bloodshed. Throughout his exegesis of French

History, Thiellement (2024) highlights a conflict between revolutionary carnivalesque and reactionary forces, and one of its first major historical expressions, the French Revolution, which the most conservative political movements either want to erase from history, like the Nazis (Chapoutot 2012, 44), or admire only for its male brutality, like the French fascists (Sand 1991).

My small academic responsibility is therefore to inscribe my texts in the revolutionary rather than reactionary tradition. I hope my humble contribution aligns with Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Edipus* (1983) which

often leads one to believe it is all fun and games, when something essential is taking place, something of extreme seriousness: the tracking down of all varieties of fascism, from the enormous ones that surround and crush us to the petty ones that constitute the tyrannical bitterness of our everyday lives. (Foucault 1983, xiv)

The challenge is therefore to reflect on my field of study, Game Studies, in order to establish a research framework that keeps visible the struggles linked to murderous colonialism, absurd military medicalisation and marginalising normative institutions. Inspired by Edgar Morin's (2021, 9) triad of *Homo Faber*, *Homo Economicus* and *Homo Ludens*, I propose a new anthropological figure: players. This figure tries to answer existentialist questions, i.e., questions linked to the loss of meaning, with an ironic hope, i.e., a hope that goes beyond the Empire's rationality. Limited to the creation of a text, my 'players' can only provide answers on a mythical level, i.e., on a narrativisation that answers to the loss of meaning; they are Camusian Sisyphuses (cf. Camus 1942). Thus, questions linked to colonisation and marginalisation are not answered here, since they require material and social responses, ranging from debate to armed struggle, which are beyond my academic power. Players are thought of as the utopian counterpart to Empire's dystopia, representing the ironic revolutionary hope (cf. section 1.3.3.), the awareness and destruction of the magic circle (cf. Huizinga [1949] 1998), the escape from the island of *Lost* (Lindelof and Abrams 2004) against an ever more concentrated (Taneja et al. 2025) and militarised (SIPRI 2025) power, whose employees become ever more alienated (Commune 2018; Rodier 2024), and whose mediocre imagination is illustrated in the *Severance* series (Erickson 2022). The role of the academic is the same as that of the poet, in that she is part of a tradition and hopes that it will serve future generations; it is through the legacy of artefacts that

archaeology of knowledge is possible. Each artefact of this tradition reflects both its Empire and its players.

The present master's thesis aims to establish a theoretical framework in which players are defined as subversive power. To justify such a renewal of definition, I provide an ontological framework, i.e., the players' modes and limits of existence, and an epistemological framework, i.e., the scientific methods and limits tied to it. What cannot be externally justified are the axioms of my thesis—necessary to any consistent system—that can be understood more poetically as the 'cosmogony' of the players' myth, condensed as follows:

- 1) If something exists, it can be situated in space, flow through time, and make possible a multiplicity of truths.
- 2) There are various degrees of existence.
- 3) Embodied existence is worthwhile.

The epistemological consequences of these axioms follow the method proposed by Foucault (1969) in his introduction to *L'Archéologie du Savoir*. He establishes an epistemological method—that is, how knowledge can be produced and limited in a science—summarised, with a touch of freedom, as the definition of thresholds, interactions, scales and systems (cf. Foucault 1969, 11). To give a rational and linear form to this creation of knowledge, like that of a master's thesis, it is necessary to produce series, i.e., collections of events that constitute a coherent vocabulary (cf. Rorty 1989, 9).

The first axiom implies the creation of a categorisation into groups of three, which constitutes the most extreme limit to the present thesis's rational explanation; the second axiom a possible hierarchisation, that is, a spectrum with two poles; and the third axiom the existence and agency of things outside of any rational explanations.

The categorisation into three gives a central position to the Two, i.e., the threshold, the intermediate layer and intersection. These are ontological groupings, because each category exists only thanks to the other two; and they are epistemological groupings, because they allow liminal phenomena to emerge into consciousness. The One and Three thus have situating and polarising functions, that is, they give the before and after of the threshold, the subject and object

of experience, the smallest and the largest, the cause and the consequence, in short, the two poles of a spectrum. They make it possible to explain a hierarchical binary in order to extract a theory. The situating function “founds a science by detaching it from the ideology of its past and by revealing this past as ideological” (Althusser 1965, 168; cited in Foucault 1969, 12), so it makes it possible to deterritorialise knowledge (cf. Deleuze and Guattari 1980; David-Ménard 2008), i.e., to make it accessible to the reader so that it can be reproduced and transformed. This laying bare of knowledge is political, since it aims to deconstruct hierarchised binaries, and it decides on the conflict that it considers unjust in the hope of subverting it. The centrality of the Two transforms the ‘What’ into ‘How’. In the words of Detective Columbo explaining the epistemological power of his own series: “This isn't really a whodunit, it's more of a how-he-did-it” (Swakchamer 1990, 01:22:00-01:22:03).

The Zero is outside the rationality of this thesis; it is the non-category or unintelligible category. Although silent (cf. Mazis 2016), its existence is necessary as *the nothing that makes it possible to situate everything*. It belongs to the realm of esotericism found in instinct, chance, or mysticism. This is the ultimate stratum of explanation as presented (only a week before Columbo) by Dale Cooper in the *Twin Peaks* series:

As a member of the Bureau I spend most of my time seeking simple answers to difficult questions. In pursuit of Laura's killer, I have used Bureau guidelines, deductive technique, Tibetan method, instinct and luck. But now I find myself in need of something new. Which, for lack of a better word, we will call *magic*. (Hunter 1990, 00:28:38-00:29:00)

This Zero is nonetheless guided by the fact that, as a human being, I have my situation and my own beliefs. In their most mystical parts, my beliefs are part of the tradition of Love, guiding the annihilated Soul over Reason, as expressed by Marguerite Porete ([1295] 2011). In their most political parts, they are aligned with Rorty's liberal democratic hope (1989; 1991), “divided between the agents of love and the agents of justice” (1991, 206).

The use of detective figures is not arbitrary: the work of research, the creation of new knowledge, has already been identified with enquiry in pragmatic philosophy (cf. Capps 2023). This investigation is the creation of the vocabulary needed to elucidate the case of Martial Richoz, *L'homme bus*, for example.

The goal of my thesis is to let reemerge a figure of players as existing between their games' worlds and the institutional world. More than a simple problem, such a task, the definition of an existence, implies a myriad of questions I attempt to select and answer throughout the present thesis. The figure of Martial Richoz illustrates this in almost all of its aspects.

In his documentary *Martial Richoz dit l'homme bus* (1983), Michel Ether films and interviews the eponymous real-life fantastic character of Martial Richoz, through which the players' existence is epitomised. Martial's most noticeable characteristic is that he goes around the streets of Lausanne dressed as a bus driver, pushing a cart, and playing a make-believe game where he is a trolleybus driver, and his cart is the trolleybus. Three kinds of considerable efforts are to be noticed in his game. First, Martial's game is not effortless: he built his trolley with recycled material, demonstrating skilful artistic creativity (Ferreira, Maugué, and Maulini 2020, 264), and drew maps of the complex networks of overhead lines for his fictional trolleybus proving his technical knowledge about them. Second, Martial's game is meaningful because he can situate it. He explains its origins:

What society calls my "madness" is nothing else than a terrible suffering that transformed itself into a depression. The only thing that keeps me going is my trolleys, so my carts or [showing his cart] this thing here. Even if it is not a real steering wheel, it already has great power over me because it *represents* a vehicle. (Ether 1983, 00:05:15-00:05:35)

He can use his game as a framework for the interpretation of things outside of it, as in the following emancipating critique of social institutions:

But what are laws? What is money? What is work? What are all these obligations in life? Isn't it a kind of overhead line we have to follow? And if you step out of line, if you go too far left or too far right, or if you take the wrong road switch—in other words, for those who don't understand the switch—you'll be frowned upon by society, and if you're frowned upon by society, sometimes you'll be arrested, sometimes you'll be interned. So shouldn't we be trying to give people the trolley pole¹? (Ether 1983, 00:15:25-00:16:00)

¹ The trolley pole is what connects the trolleybus to the overhead line.

Third, Martial performs his activity. He creates dialogues between and plays different roles from the bus company, and even plays the vehicle itself by imitating the trolley bus sounds. It is thus, with enough imagination, possible to enter Martial's game world by understanding and performing its codes and rules.

Finally, Martial takes some distance from his game. Although it constitutes a major part of his life he does not place an absolute certitude on its value. In this sense, he declares toward the end of the documentary: "I don't even know if I really like trolleys. I don't really know. I might even not know anything at all" (Ether 1983, 00:16:31-00:16:41).

The eccentricity of his game cost him being interned by force in a psychiatric hospital in January 1986 (Ferreira, Maugué, and Maulini 2020, 5) without any medical proof of a psychiatric condition, not even during the judiciary decision of his liberation (123). This conflict between social institutions and players guides the different questions asked throughout my research. More than just a victim of the psychiatric institutions of his time, Martial Richoz illustrates what it means to be a *radical player*, and how the mechanisms of an authoritarian regime are constructed to marginalise such existences.

My thesis aims to develop in the reader an intuition of what players are, not as a definite category of individuals but as an ontological movement that can be de- and reterritorialised—i.e., translated—into various contexts and applications: "I am going to try to make the vocabulary I favor look attractive by showing how it may redescribe a variety of topics." (Rorty 1989, 9).

To orient the reader throughout the present master thesis, I propose diagrams (Figure 1, Figure 2, Figure 3), which constitute general maps of where my research can be situated. While the content of the three figures completely becomes clear only after reading my thesis, their structure provides a global view of my scientific method as detailed in this introduction. They should help the reader travel through the thesis, i.e., to exist with it.

In poetic terms, for a thing to exist, "it is not necessary to live, it is necessary to travel" (Burroughs 1986, 149). What this means in the ontological framework of the present thesis is that existence happens in the liminal space between ontological realms. Thus, there are three

types of travel: *expression* between the World and the Self, *ritual* between the Self and the Other, and *system* between the Other and the World. Each of these travels has two poles, one fostering stability and the other instability. On the stable side, expression is “pure repetition” (Landes 2013, 4), ritual is “normative social structure” (Turner, 1974: 59), and a system is “self-organisation” (Rietveld et al. 2018, 52), whereas on the unstable side, expression is “pure creation” (Landes 2013, 4), ritual is “anti-structure” (Turner, 1974: 65), and a system is “emergence” (Bich 2006, 284)—in an enactivist cognitive approach (cf. Di Paolo 2018). Travel always happens in the mythical space (cf. Merleau-Ponty [1945] 1976, 336), situated by the ontological layers it transgresses and the direction it has. Travel unifies layers through transgression, but also only happens because the layers are separated by ontological gaps, i.e., boundaries (cf. Ryan 2004, 451). These ontological gaps belong to the invisible world, which is vertically organised, in the depth of the flesh beyond the intelligible and re-emerges through affects that one can be conscious of (Mazis 2016; Merleau-Ponty 1968).

Figure 1: Ontological limits and their intersections

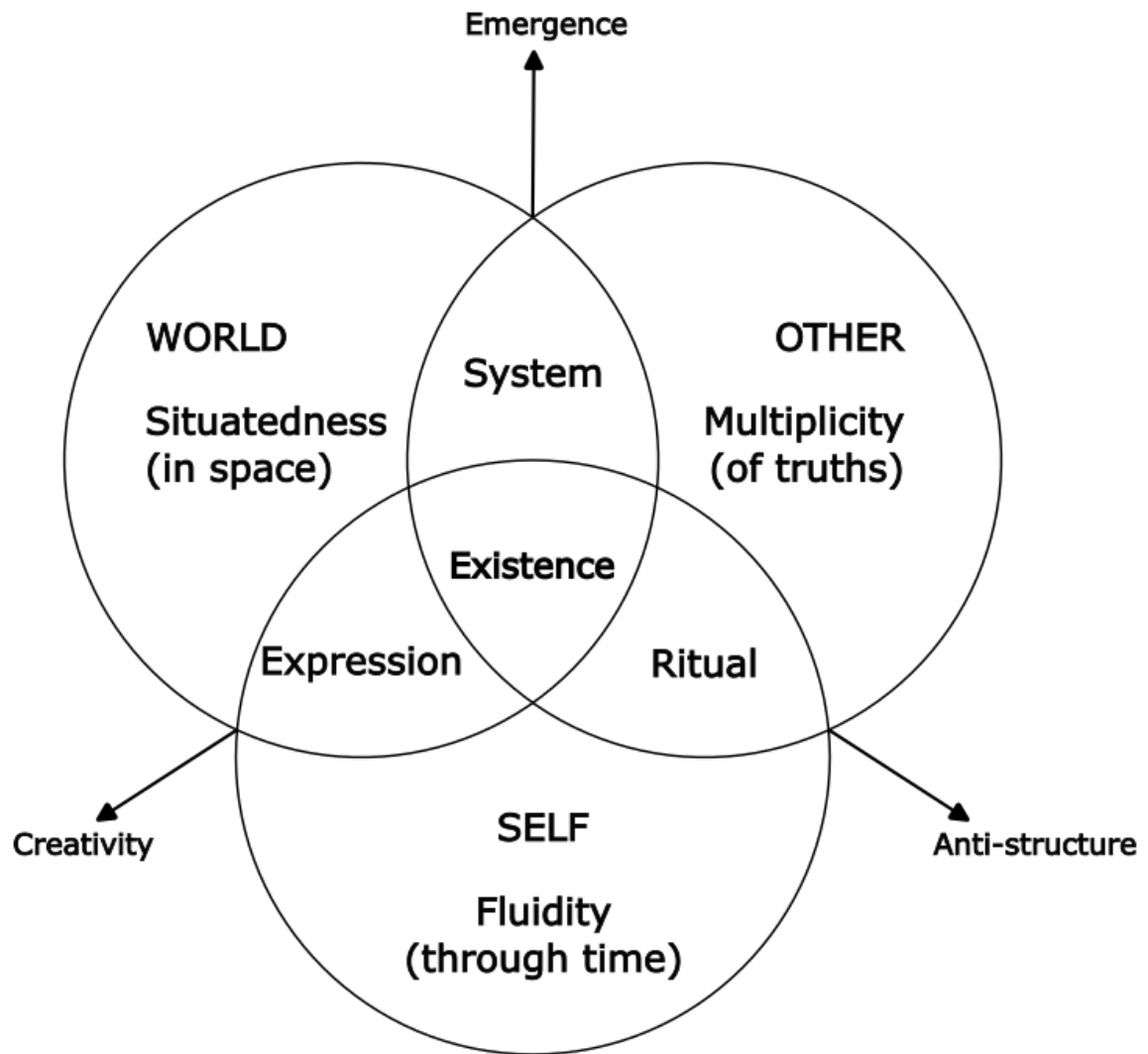


Figure 2: Ontological layers and their interactions

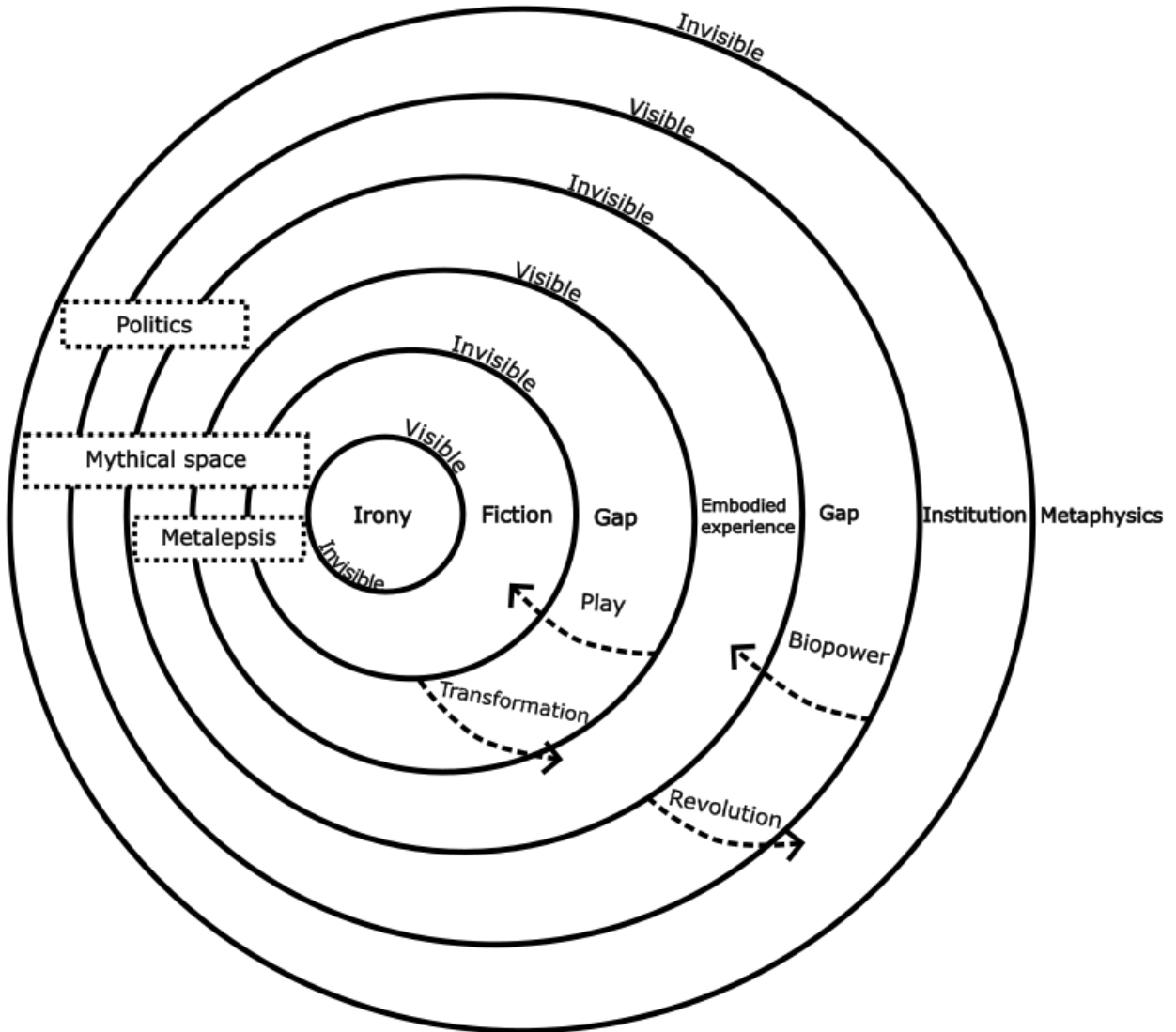
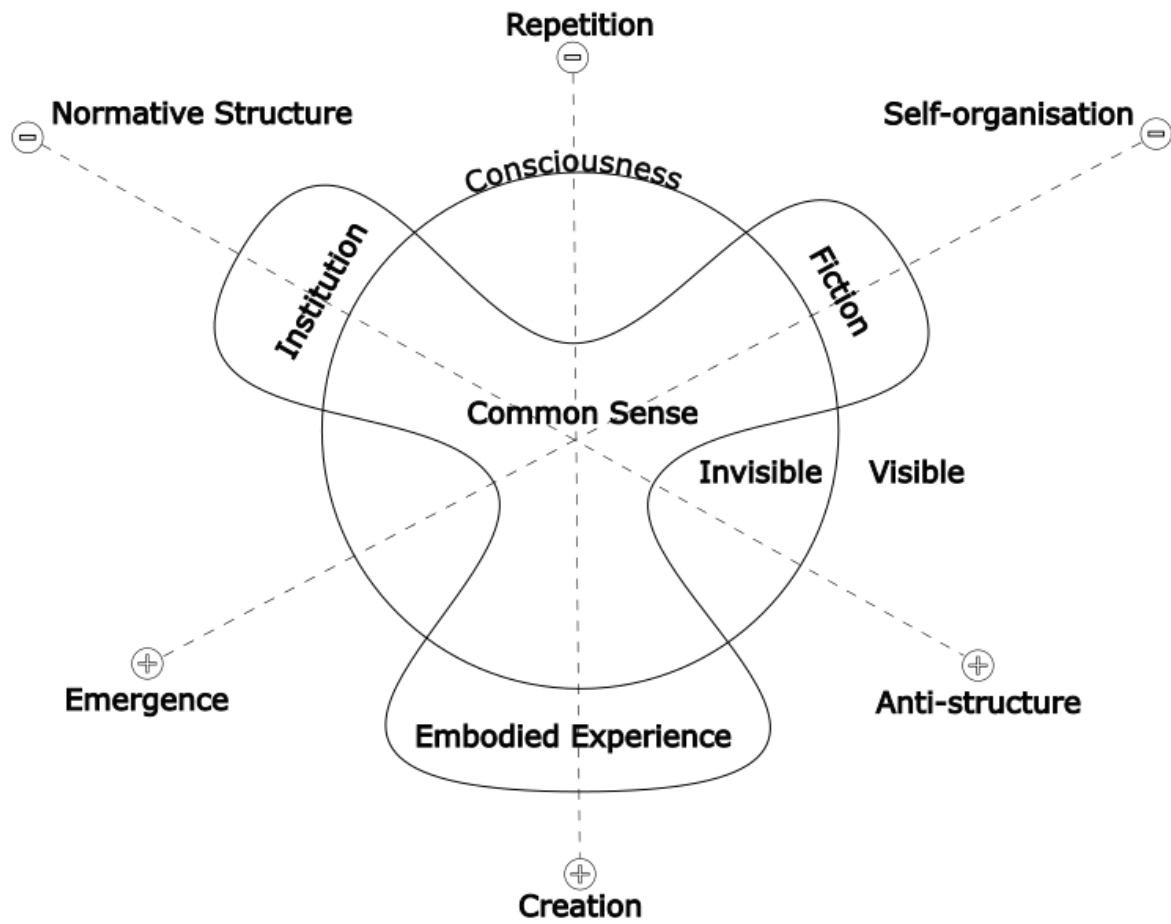


Figure 3: Epistemological thresholds and their interactions



XXX Add authors for chapters. Add the most important authors/texts of your theoretical framework as references to the overview/structure section (p).

Chapter 1 therefore presents the two ontological complexities that give games their characteristic methods of analysis. The modes of existence proper for games are comparable, different, and included in the wider context of social life imposed by institutions through rules and roles; they anchor players in Barthe's ([1957] 1961) mythological approach, theories about the Chinese concept of 'face' as translated by Hu (1944), and Rorty's (1989) liberal ironist figure. Chapter 2 gives the reader the theoretical tools to understand the problematisation of the present thesis: the opposition between players and Empire. It ultimately is a categorisation of categories themselves as *fluid*, *situated* and *multiple*, not only justifying a wide range of fields of study to be used throughout the thesis's argumentation but also allowing the reader to implement their own theories into this meta-category.

Leaving the abstract metaphors of Chapter 2 behind, Chapter 3 focuses on Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology as established in *Phénoménologie de la Perception* (1945), allowing the reader to anchor different theories into the realm of their embodied experience and pushing rational categories to their limit, where they are the most meaningful on the individual scale. This phenomenological situation serves as a transition toward the complete situation of players opposed to Empire established in Chapter 4. Throughout this Chapter, the abstract poetic theories of Chapter 2 are confronted with the reality of Empire where the reader can situate their experience mainly building on Foucault's political philosophy theories and Hardt and Negri's *Empire* (2000).

Chapter 5 weaves a long thread to argue that a change of situation is a change of temporality, and thus two different situations can be compared within the same framework if their relative temporality is established. Pavel's *Fictional Worlds* (1986) and Ryan's *Narrative as Virtual Reality* (2001) offer the spatiotemporal account of the phenomenology of fiction that is the closest to players' experience but requires some extensions to be situated in the institutional and mythical space; it is anchored in the institutional reality on one end with Caillois's theories about game and sacred spaces ([1939] 1988) and on the other with Halbwachs's sociological framing of memory ([1925] 1976); it is anchored in the mythical space with Eliade's narrativisations of temporality (1949; 1967). This relative temporality is proper to players as travellers of

temporalities, subjectivities able to let go of a situation to be transformed by another. The crisis of temporality in players' experience is then explored through the production of nostalgia in Chapter 6. Boym's *The Future of Nostalgia* (2001) provides an impressively cohesive account of nostalgia that covers virtually all the ontological realms I established throughout my thesis; my contribution to the study of nostalgia only enriches it with the phenomenological study of video games and French retrogaming. A study of liminal affects showcases how Empire produces the categories and conditions necessary for the expression of liminal affects, an expression which, in turn, is marginalised through processes of annihilation and assimilation. This Chapter allows the reader to generalise the case of Martial Richoz as an iconic player figure to other cases where the creative and emancipating use of liminal affects is marginalised by the oppressive structures of Empire. My conclusion finally open the possibilities for player figures to be found in any movement that employs creation, rupture, and emancipation against established structures, i.e., any movement animated by players themselves to subvert the roles imagined before them.

Although a wiki format would have been more appropriate for my task, the ideas are organised in order of complexity—with the exception of Chapter 6—and the first Chapter confronts the reader to concrete and easily imaginable situations that should progressively ease the linear reading of my thesis.

1. Ontological Delimitation of Games

1.1. Games as material, meaningful and social.

Play can be used to define three different modes of existence that are a) the material, b) the meaningful and c) the social. a) To live in a game means to make the necessary effort to be able to continue playing. In closed games, i.e. in games that have a determined ending (Suits 1978), it is to avoid the game's excluding sanctions before the end of the game, for instance, not getting a red card during a football match or preventing the avatar from dying in a game with permanent death. In open games, the opposite of closed games, players have to sustain the desired state of affairs attained through play; in brief, it is to keep playing. b) For play to constitute a meaningful experience, players need to pretend to believe in the game's world, to accept the temporary truth

values established by the game. At least, for example in simulations, it requires players to understand their purpose in the context of the game and to accept the established goal as theirs. In games that present unnatural elements of fiction, players need to interpret these elements to make them meaningful. c) Finally, for a social existence in a game, players are required to perform a role that can be identified by the other inhabitants of the game's world—whether they are human or not. It is through the performance of in-game identities that players can communicate with each other.

All these aspects have their real-world counterparts. To live in the real world is to have the material means of existence, obtained through work, exploitation, or solidarity. To make meaning in the real world is to find the function or the purpose of things, to be able to understand them to a point where their form and content make one and do not need further explanation. To perform in the real world is to act and react accordingly to social codes, and to save face.

1.1.1. The empty soda can blind test

To illustrate these three modes of existence in games, I will give a personal experience of a DIY guess-the-song game. My friends and I are used to playing guess-the-song games, called *blind tests* in France, usually finding them ready made on YouTube. This one time, because of the general tiredness and the late hour, instead of using speakers and the original soundtracks, we used an empty soda can on which one would tap the rhythm of a song and the others had to guess it. The evolution of the game showed solutions to the problems raised by continuing to play while making everyone have a purpose and developing a form of expressivity. These problems were solved multiple times through multiple formal questions.

First, the formal question of who plays with the empty soda can has seen an evolution of the rules throughout the game, adapting to existential needs. The first person to play was the one who suggested the idea of playing. Then we would give the can to the person who correctly guessed the song first. Doing this gives a reward, and a sense of purpose for the guessers, giving more room for creativity, i.e. being able to choose and play the song through a change of role. After a while, having exhausted all the obvious songs to play, the first one to have an idea would take the empty soda can and start playing to prevent the game's pace from being broken by overly long times of reflection. During this phase, the one to hold the can and play a song was no

longer a reward, but a necessary role to fulfill as quickly as possible. The sense of purpose and role were confounded for the greater good of keeping the game alive. Later, my friends and I would no longer strictly play the game and everyone took an empty can to play minimalist musical improvisations, with different configurations—there were mostly successions of solos and duos.² After exhausting our musical creativity, we shortly played the two precedent variants before we stopped the game.

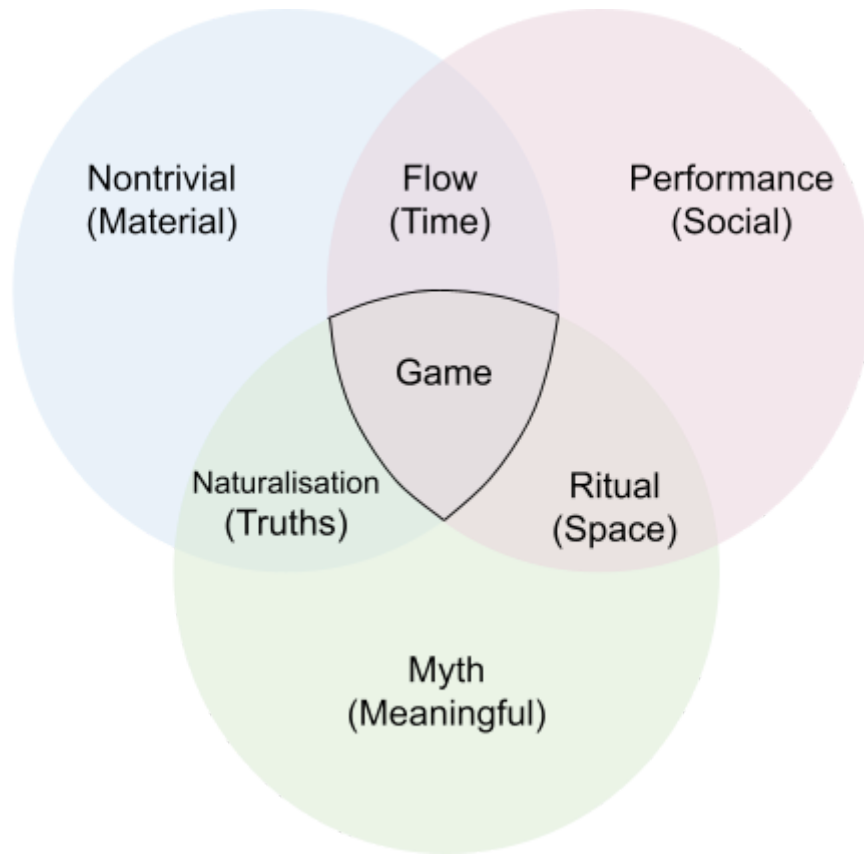
A similar analysis can be done by focusing not on how to earn the empty can but on how to get rid of it, i.e., how to finish the mini-game of guessing a song. Social existence is kept through the same mechanism because all players have a chance to change their roles during a round. To keep the game alive, the ‘can player’ has to ensure that guessing the song stays non-trivial but possible effort by giving hints or changing the song for instance. The meaningful riddance of the can is done through a miniature ritual where the can player is vanquished—because her song has been guessed or because they abandoned—and transmits her role to her successor.

As such, a game could thus be summed up as a nontrivial performance of a ritual. The nontriviality ensures the material existence in the game, a resistance through which players flow, a life they have to maintain. The ritual ensures the meaningful existence in the game, a purpose that players fulfil in the myth they enact. The performance ensures social existence in the game, an identity that allows interactions within the game, the face players have to save.

² A psychoanalytical approach to this third phase would probably consider it as a release of the frustrations caused by the previous phase but the methodology I use for my thesis needs to keep itself distant from intentions and consciousness.

1.1.2. Tripartite theoretical ontological approach to games.

Figure 4: Tripartite theoretical ontological approach to games.



The different combinations of the elements of play give one the categorisation of game studies approach I establish in my thesis. The performance of myth is the oldest approach to games, the one established by Huizinga ([1949] 1998), who compares games to sacred spaces due to their separation and liminality from the ordinary world. Aarseth (1997) popularised a definition of games as nontrivial myths in his definition of ergodic literature requiring a nontrivial effort “to allow the reader to traverse the text” (1). However, I consider theories that place the reader’s experience of a text as active, as a transportation between the real world and the fictional world workable with games, especially Barthe’s *From Work to Text* (1979), where the readers are defined as ‘players of text’. This approach explores the truth values of games. Finally, the study of games as nontrivial performances focuses on the state of affairs reached through games. Without any meaning, this is best analysed as the flow state, first defined as

the state in which people are so involved in an activity that nothing else seems to matter; the experience itself is so enjoyable that people will do it even at great cost, for the sheer sake of doing it. (Csikszentmihalyi 2008, 13)

While flow is the general term for the psychological—or even biological—that makes one's experience enjoyable and captivating, I choose to focus on liminal affects that, as flow, are both captivating and require specific efforts to reach. For instance, nostalgia requires one to memorise, to long for a no-longer existing thing, to reach an in-between state where one is attracted by something one can never reach. This approach focuses on experience itself, without searching for a beginning or an end.

1.1.3. Myth-Ritual theory

Myth-ritual theory is not unified, if but an their interest in the link between myth and ritual (Segal 2011, 69). Rather than selecting an approach as the 'correct' one, I let open the question of

whether a myth is (1) a narrative which is recited as a part of a ritual, (2) a narrative, the events of which are enacted in a ritual, (3) a narrative which is both recited and enacted in a ritual, or (4) a narrative which is only indirectly and secondarily associated with ritual. (Bascom 1957, 113-114)

This echoes the narratologist-ludologist debate in game studies trying to answer whether games should be considered narratives or practices, stories or rules, and how the two sides interrelate. In game studies, it is observable that theories that consider accepting narrative and practice as tied define games as spaces (Huizinga [1949] 1998; Caillois [1939] 1988; 1958; Jenkins 2004; Nitsche 2009). With the exception of Jenkins, game-as-space theories treat the question of the sacred, either in the Durkheimian tradition, studying the separation between the sacred and the profane, or the Eliadian, studying the pervasiveness of the sacred in the profane. What games offer when they are considered as spaces is a union of form and content, a harmony of the practice with its narrative that is only meaningful within a delimited time and place. This is what Merleau-Ponty calls the mythical space (Merleau-Ponty 1945; Mazis 2016), in which “things are taken for the incarnation of what they express, for the human meaning collapses into it and offers

itself literally as what they mean” (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 336). Myths are not taken as a representation but as a ‘true presence’ (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 335), a term that would later be used by Barthes to express the presence of the linguistic signified in the mythical signifier through the merging of the linguistic meaning into the mythical form (3. and I on Table 1) (Barthes 2006, 115).

Table 1: Barthe’s imbricated linguistic and mythic systems (Barthes 2006, 113)

Language MYTH	{	{	1. Signifier	2. Signified	
			3. Sign I SIGNIFIER		II SIGNIFIED
			III SIGN		

1.1.4. Myth readers, myth producers and mythologists as alienated players, game designers, and critical players.

Myths are the basis of meaning-making. When one is not part of the culture in which a myth makes sense, there is a need for interpretation. Barthes makes the distinction between three attitudes toward myths. Firstly, the readers of myth who “focus on the mythical signifier as an inextricable whole made of meaning and form” (2006, 127), which is the acceptance of the section hereabove. Secondly, the mythologists who “clearly distinguish the meaning and the form, and consequently the distortion which one imposes on the other” (ibid.). And finally, of the producers of myths who “let the concept fill the form of the myth without ambiguity”(ibid.), creating “a simple system, where the signification becomes literal again” (ibid.), so the form becomes a symbol for the concept.

The [last] two types of focusing are static, analytical; they destroy the myth, either by making its intention obvious, or by unmasking it: the former is cynical, the latter demystifying. The [first]

type of focusing is dynamic, it consumes the myth according to the very ends built into its structure: the reader lives the myth as a story at once true and unreal. (Barthes 2006, 127)

To clarify this theory, let me first adapt these terms to games, which will also allow me to refine the scope of my thesis. If games are considered mythical spaces, they must be created, understood and then lived, experienced. Players must be “penetrated by them and penetrate into them, and they become intimate” (Mazis 2016, 199). The myth producer and the mythologist are not part of the actualisation of the myth, they create and deconstruct the mythical space. They play the role of the game designer, the “narrative architect” (cf. Jenkins 2004) of the game space, and the critical player (or the game studies scholar), the external interpreter of games.

For the scope of my thesis, I leave aside the game designer, focusing on the player. In Carse’s terms (1986), the myth reader is the role played by a participant in a game and the mythologist is the person who plays the game. Carse makes the distinction between infinite players, the equivalent of what I call critical players, designating players able to dissociate the role they play from who they are, and finite players who make one with their role. My thesis uniquely considers players as the people who can both play a role and distinguish between the person and the role, i.e. the only people considered players are Carse’s infinite players. Finite players fall under Caillouis’s alienated player category, the corruption of mimicry (1958, 83), something not considered play and that I treat as the simple reproduction of existing power structures. In short, when working with games as mythical spaces, players find themselves to be both *in* the game as ritual performers, and *out of* the game as interpreters and meaning-makers.

1.2. Games and liminality

The difficulty to generalise whether an activity defined as such is play or a serious everyday life activity is due to the relativity of the ontological border between the domain of play existence and everyday life existence. One can be detached from one’s material existence without a hierarchy between one’s own biological body and the rest of the material world; or detached from one’s meaningful existence, considering that there is no absolute truth, but that the multitude of truths is hierarchically equal; or detached from one’s social existence, considering

one's identity as multiple without hierarchies between them. For the scope of this thesis, I consider games as ontologically inferior to real, everyday life. This ontological boundary will be treated as porous, flexible and unstable, through the binaries of fiction-reality, and extraordinary-everyday (the game equivalent to profane-sacred).

1.2.1. Simple introduction to game's double situatedness

To work on the boundary between games and reality, one needs to consider games as fictional worlds, and to work on the boundary between institutions and reality, it is necessary to understand institutions as games and reality as the game of everyday life. Institutions are the sacred games.

Are video games unique in offering a vicarious body in a virtual world? Are they so different from actors playing characters on a stage? One clear difference is that they do not have the same effect as real-life experiences: no game makes its players die forever, banishing them from playing, like when an actor plays the death of her character at the end of a tragedy. What makes it so different? They are not completely disconnected from real life either. If my video game character dies in a game, I feel genuinely frustrated, and actors running away from an imaginary monster are actually shouting and running on a green screen. Is the actor's stage so radically different from the video game's world? When my character dies when I play a video game, I do say that I am dead. The game even tells me 'you lose' when I am knocked out by M.Bison in *Street Fighter II* (Capcom 1991). But when an actor's character dies, the audience does not ask the actor why she let Juliet kill herself. Intuitively, all these remarks seem to work, but there are counterexamples. When in *Red Dead Redemption 2* (Rockstar Games 2018) Arthur Morgan dies, I do not lose, but I actually just follow the story. I am both the actor who led him to die and the spectator crying for his death. The actor cannot cry during his performance of death, and the audience is not responsible for the character's death. Players do both.

Games do not seem to be completely detached islands of reality, as much as movies can be. Yet are they completely integrated in real life? What makes it so different to say: "I am Ryu and I need to win this tournament" and "I am a student and I need to finish this thesis"? Intuitively, the

former is a fictional statement and the latter a real one. Looking at the two statements with a bit of distance, one can see that the former appears as separated from any other context—Ryu only exists in the tournament—while the student needs to finish a thesis in the course of her studies, as part of an academic career, itself in the course of a working life where different institutions give her the means for her existence³. Institutions are “complex social forms that reproduce themselves such as governments, the family, human languages, universities, hospitals, business corporations, and legal systems” (Miller 2024, np). In other words, an activity is ‘play’ when it is useless for my existence, and work when it is useful. The question here is to know what makes it valuable to institutions and what not.

However, scholars in the field of game studies, and one of its founders, Huizinga, argue that playing is *not* a useless activity, on the same level as sacred activities are not useless. But whereas Buddha or Ryu do not pay my rent, some of the other aforementioned institutions do. Are those of the same nature as a god or a fictional character? Do they not have responsible concrete human beings behind them, responsible for them, but at the same time obligated to perform certain roles in them? The personnel of institutions are both actors and spectators of their work, but it is not considered a game because of the impact on their (and other people’s) existence. Is working at these institutions part of everyday life? They have their separate time and place and require effort to be able to be part of or to leave them. They have their codes and rules, their community, and ask one to play a role. However, they have direct power over the lives of individuals—except for the very privileged ones—, even outside of their spaces, or rather, there is virtually nowhere outside of their power. Whereas M. Bison does not send me letters to tell me I have lost, the WienerLinien can send me letters for a fine I did not pay, and work with the network of institutions that have power over me. If I were a minor, they could contact my parents, the police, or the court. However, institutions only accept communication with other institutions and characters playing in them. I have to play a fare evader and present myself as such to the different institutions concerned. The power of institutions is that for every situation, whether I fail or succeed in following the rules, there is a character ready for me to embody that has to follow predetermined rules.

³ In the exceptional cases of professional *Street Fighter II* players, the same context appears.

1.2.2. Sociological background and link with collective memory

Simple observations about the structuralising limits of play show that its analysis allows one to categorise human activity ‘into’ play and ‘non-play’. Such categorisation can be traced back to Durkheim's sociological work on the sacred and the profane (1915), two spheres of human culture that are defined by being separated. It is possible to look at liminal cases of play to understand better what it is. Moreover, play is liminal *outside* itself, between pure fiction, acting, and pure reality, everyday life social activities, but also *within* itself between the fictional world, the forgetting that one is playing, and the real world, the consciousness that one is playing without which it would not be play. As such, theories on collective memory observe similar phenomena. There are social frames of play, play as the actualisation, the work of fiction, and play as a separate place from everyday life that is the presence of the imaginary (cf. Lavabre 2020). As much as memory is what connects one to one's past, play is what connects one to one's imagination.

Lavabre (2020) makes a distinction between three approaches toward collective memories that were developed, in the second half of the 20th century and identified through the concepts of *lieux de mémoire*, “sites of memory”, (Nora 1978), of *travail de mémoire* (Ricoeur 2000), “memory work”, and of *cadres sociaux de la mémoire* (Halbwachs [1925] 1976), social frames of memory. She summarises these three superposable and compatible approaches as follows:

The first is associated with the reflection of Pierre Nora on **the political usages of the past and the national identity** and refers to the historical field. The second relates to the one of Paul Ricoeur about the forgetting and the reconciliation in societies that are torn apart by conflict and is explicitly part of the **citizen and politico-normative preoccupation**. The third constitutes the Halbwachsian heritage and questions the **evocation of the past's social condition**. (Lavabre 2020, np; translation and emphasis by me)

The first approach—the sites of memory—distinguishes between historical objects and memory, differentiating objective signs of the past and the narratives constructed from these objects. It suggests that a comprehensive analysis of institutions needs to go back to the objects of the past themselves before they entered political discourse. The second approach (memory work) is concerned with the differentiation between the historical past and memory, defined as “the present of the past”, a formula coined by Saint Augustin but most famously cited by Paul Ricoeur (1983, 37). It stems from an established characteristic of memory, which “does not in any way reconstitute the past, it does not reproduce it, it does not establish it” (Lavabre 2020, np). It

is related to the poststructuralist concept of ‘*différance*’, coined by Derrida (1967) to describe the constant deferral and differentiation of the meaning of a sign, the “formation of the form” (92, my translation). The third approach grounds memory in people's social practices, in that collective memory is a discriminatory factor in determining one's identification with a group. Through this Halbwachsian approach, Assman and Czaplicka (1995) make the distinction between communicative and cultural memory. The former concerns everyday communication, in its aspects of “non-specialization, reciprocity of roles, thematic instability, and disorganization” (126), as opposed to cultural memory which is “characterized by its distance from the everyday” (129). Cultural memory “is maintained through cultural formation (texts, rites, monuments) and institutional communication (recitation, practice, observance)” (ibid.), called “figures of memory” (ibid.). These constitute “islands of time [that] expand into memory spaces of ‘retrospective contemplativeness’”(ibid.). From this perspective, collective memory theories allow one to work on games as ‘islands of time’.

1.2.3. The concept of Face in the face of a game's liminality

A second concept, on a list of rules that I want to cover, is that of ‘honour’, to which the concept of ‘face’ is opposed (Ho 1976). The goal, as with every power mechanism, is to see the horizontal, playable alternative to its stable structures. Rare are the non-psychological approaches to honour, that explain one's behaviour through social structures and not through fixed expected emotional reactions—the latter hardly useable for my thesis because of my methodology which needs to minimise individual intention or consciousness. Generally defined, honour is a “multiphenomenal category of concepts that, as a system, hierarchically structure society by inscribing value onto an individual by an Other” (Oprisko 2012, 159). The linear understanding of honour implies that one can win or lose honour, win or lose social value, very much like a game. In Chinese terminology, it is *mien-tzu*, the quantity and quality of honour in a certain group (Ho 1976, 869). The process for winning is *prestige* and the one for losing is *shame*, increasing or decreasing one's social position respectively (Oprisko 2012, 6). The absolute goal in the ‘honour game’ is *glory*,

the combination of fame and honour. This process of honor echoes across time and space. Glory possesses a sacred quality and elevates a societal exemplar to become a

transcendent exemplar par excellence of a particular quality or action. Glory manifests itself in myths and legends. (Oprisko 2012, 7)

It is absolute because it is transcendent, sacred, and mythic, meaning that its existence is self-sufficient. It is an end because once glorified, one is made eternal, through time and space, meaning that one is definitively ‘out of the game’. The Chinese equivalent to glory is the generalised—not limited to one group—*mien-tzu* which is only given to “national heroes, scholars who have made lasting contributions to human knowledge, poets of time-honored repute, and the like” (Ho 1976, 869).

A non-linear, horizontal alternative to honour is ‘face’. Although face is the translation for both *mien-tzu* and *lien*, Goffman⁴ (1989), Oprisko and Ho use it as a translation of *lien* for its sociological meaning. *Lien* can either be maintained or lost through inadequate social interactions, a failure to meet others’ expectations. It expresses the confidence that a group can have for one to correctly play one’s role. Hu (1944) has five variations of this concept:

- 1) *Tiu-lien* describes that one can lose *lien* because of a lack of responsibility associated with one's power (46).
- 2) *Kei mou-mou-jên tiu-lien* is the lost of *lien* for the group one is affiliated to (50).
- 3) *Pu-yao lien* describes when one does not want *lien*, not in the sense that one is excentric, but that one disregards the rules for one’s own benefit, taking advantage of others (51).
- 4) *Mei-yu lien*, to not have *lien*, can be summed up as a stronger moral condemnation than not wanting it (52).
- 5) *Lien-pi’i hou* or *po*, as the skin on the *lien* can be thin or thick, which expresses one’s resistance to losing *lien*, and the sensibility to the other’s judgement (54).

Face is a way to acknowledge that players “regard each participant in finite play as that *person playing* and not as a *role played* by someone” (Carse 1986, 15), something that is commonly described as the *beau jeu*. A *beau joueur*, literally translated as the “beautiful player”, closer to the meaning of ‘fair player’, is someone who “plays frankly, and offers the opponent a chance to

⁴ Goffman does not explicitly make this translation but is aware of the Chinese conception of ‘face’ defined by Hu (1944) as he writes in a footnote (Goffman 1989, 5n2).

recover” (Littré 1874, 198; my translation)⁵. Caillois’s definition of the *beau joueur* only accounts for the acceptance of losing through an apparent detachment from the game (1958, 78-9). This acceptance of the concept of ‘detachment’ makes it seem like a protective measure for, allegedly or actually, preserving a good public image. However, this detachment is at the basis of the player’s responsibility to acknowledge the ‘preludory goal’ of other players, i.e., what state of affairs one is attempting to achieve through a game (Suits 1978, 37). This distance-taking is only possible for a player who considers the played role as ontologically inferior to the person playing—I suppose that people are not suicidal. Situationally defined, face “refers only to the immediate respect a person expects others to show in each specific instance of social encounter”, as found in Goffman’s theories (Ho 1976, 868).

1.3. Generalisation of Players and Universalisation of my Explanation

“Being takes place simultaneously and concurrently within ontological, social, and material realities without contradiction.” (Oprisko 2012, 44). Should every activity fulfill these constraints? Work, in a Marxist definition, can be understood as the non-trivial effort necessary to sustain one’s *material* existence, to sustain life, at the risk of not being able to meet biological needs for survival. Its responsibility can be shared through solidarity. Interpretation is the non-trivial effort necessary to sustain one’s *meaningful* existence, at the risk of suicide, it is shared through myths. Performance is the non-trivial effort necessary to sustain one’s *social* existence, at the risk of losing face, and it is shared in social groups. They can all be considered ‘games’ if not necessary for one’s type of existence. Martial Richoz’s game, as explored in the introduction, is a remedy for his deep suffering, his depression, making it necessary for his meaningful experience. *For one to be able to play, one must have at least one type of existence that is not at risk.*

The existential dread that separates games from non-games, the liminality of games, can be refined and reframed through Turner’s concepts of liminal and liminoid. The following paragraphs thus reread the Turner’s theories in the way they reveal the ontological and existential implications of my players definition.

⁵ I ask the reader to temporarily accept this outdated definition of *beau joueur* for it was the closest positively connotated term I could find expressing the idea of a distanced and honest player showing solidarity.

1.3.1. Rereading my Thesis through Turner's Liminality

“It is largely through Turner’s writings that the concept of liminality has come to pervade a host of fields and disciplines” (Stephenson 2020, 2). Game Studies (cf. Horrigan 2021; Jiao 2024) and the present thesis are no exception. Turner (1974) situates his approach to liminality in “comparative symbology” (54), something relatively close to the Cultural Studies and poststructuralist theories I mobilise in the present thesis. It is “involved in the relationships between symbols and the concepts, feelings, values, notions, etc., associated with them by users, interpreters, or exegetes” (ibid.), and “[i]ts data are mainly drawn from *cultural genres* or *subsystems* of expressive culture” (ibid.; original emphasis) studying both “*activities* combining verbal and nonverbal symbolic actions ... as well as *narrative genres*” (ibid.; original emphasis). As such, it distances itself from traditional structuralist well-ordered frameworks in favour of ludic, disordered, creative ones (55). Turner builds upon Van Gennep's ([1909] 1981) works on the *rite de passage* by focusing on the transition phase between the separation and the re-aggregation of the individual going through the rite (56-7). He identifies different figures, terms, and concepts that are proper to the transition phase, from which I retain three: “marginality” (58), “unnatural” (60), and the “ludic” (61), the latter being “liminality *par excellence*” (ibid.; original emphasis).

Liminality is also characterised by the spontaneous (Turner 1974, 89) creation of “communitas”:

an unstructured or rudimentarily structured and relatively undifferentiated *comitatus*, community, or even communion of equal individuals who submit together to the general authority of the ritual elders. (Turner [1969] 1991, 96)

Moreover, ‘communitas’ has a horizontal quality, for it “tempers the pride of the incumbent of a higher position or office” (Turner [1969] 1991, 97). It is, more generally, about “people playing roles and maintaining or achieving status” (Turner 1974, 77), comparable to the concept of ‘face’ used in section 1.2.3..

Turner transports the concept of liminality from the traditional anthropology of Van Gennep, i.e., from the study of tribal societies, to the modern anthropology of contemporary Western societies. In this process, he observes that because of the fundamental structural shift from traditional sacred/profane to modern work/leisure binary (63), liminality takes the form of the liminal in the

workspace and liminoid in the leisure space. Schechner (2017) associates two types of change with liminal and liminoid:

Liminal rituals are transformations, permanently changing who people are. Liminoid rituals, effecting a temporary change—sometimes nothing more than a brief *communitas* experience or a several-hours-long playing of a role—are transportations. (Schechner 2017, 72)

Turner establishes a list of five criteria to distinguish liminal from liminoid phenomena, which I progressively comment on to highlight the links with my thesis:

1) They happen in *different kinds of societies*: liminal phenomena “tend to predominate in tribal and early agrarian societies” (Turner 1974, 84), whereas liminoid phenomena “perhaps begin to appear on the scene in city-states on their way to begin empires ... and in feudal societies” (ibid.). “[T]hey first begin to clearly to develop in Western Europe in nascent capitalist societies” (ibid.) and are “still highly visible in the post-World War Two managerial societies of organized capitalism ... of the Western bloc” (ibid.) as the new culture that “tries to synthesize, as far as possible, *humanism and technology*” (85; my emphasis). This kind of genealogy of “managerial societies” is found in the historical works cited in the present thesis, and Turner uses the liminoid as a red thread, a vanishing line along which criticism can perform its work.

The following criteria develop the conceptual oppositions between the liminal and liminoid, both flexible enough to be situated in contemporary Western societies.

2) They happen on *different scales and in different temporalities*: liminal phenomena “tend to be collective ... natural disjunctions in the flow of natural and social processes” (ibid.), “enforced by sociocultural ‘*necessity*,’” (ibid., my emphasis), and contain “the potentiality for the formation of new ideas, symbols, models, beliefs” (ibid.). In contrast, liminoid phenomena “are more characteristically individual products” (ibid.). They are “continuously generated ... in the times and places *apart from work* settings assigned to ‘leisure’ activities” (ibid.; my emphasis). Through the two poles of Pontian expressivity (cf. Landes 2013), ‘repetition’ and ‘creation’, in section 1.1.4. I analyse myth-making in the liminal space and in section 5.4.1 make-believe games in the liminoid. Both activities share the same mechanisms of deformation, but they differ in their sociocultural function: the former is necessary, and the latter is contingent.

3) They happen in *hierarchically different areas of a society*: liminal phenomena “are centrally integrated into the *total social process*” (Turner 1974, 85) while liminoid phenomena develop “along the margins, in the interfaces and interstices of central and servicing institutions—they are plural, fragmentary and experimental in character” (ibid.). This opposition is one of the pillars of my analysis framework, the *multiplicity*, as developed in section 2.3., as well as in the definition of Empire, opposing totalising power structures to the multitude of individuals constituting it, elaborated on in section 4..

4) They differ in the *mechanisms of identity formation* they operate: liminal phenomena “reflect, on probing, the history of the group, i.e., its collective experience, over time” (85) while liminoid phenomena tend to be “generated by specific named individuals and in particular groups—‘schools,’ circles, and coteries.” (ibid.). Theories on collective memory, as explored in sections 1.2.2., 2.3.3., and 5.5.2.4., make visible that this separation between the liminal and liminoid is a result of the two preceding criteria applied to memory as ‘the present of the past’.

5) They differ ontologically in their *political functions*: liminal phenomena “tend to be ultimately eufunctional” (86), while liminoid phenomena “are often parts of social critiques or even revolutionary manifestoes” (ibid.). It seems fairly obvious that if the liminal is defined by the same characteristics as a fascist regime—conservative, totalising, necessary, and generating the history of a group—the liminoid will then be defined as a revolutionary imaginary engendered by the liminal. However, it is important to note the crucial ontological difference between the effects of the liminal and the liminoid: the former frames the whole social structure in all its aspects while the latter only exists in the realm of fiction “books, plays, paintings, films, etc.”(86). I shortly explore this theme in section 4.1.2., although on a less general level, stating that a political oppositional group can only exert its power “within the existing fundamental structures” (Gramsci 1992, 216). The liminal necessarily frames the liminoid against which it is opposed.

Turner’s theories on the liminal-liminoid distinction, especially through his criteria listing, allow a broad understanding of what can be categorised as game and what cannot: it refines the description of game’s liminality to a categorisation of liminality itself.

1.3.2. *Between Liminal and Liminoid: The Absurd Existence of Players*

I think one aspect of liminality is missing in this theorisation because the *rite de passage* happens between two existing states: the liminality between existence and nothingness. It might as well be a gap in my thesis, although I attempt to cover it with the analysis of things that are outside our perception but are *attractive emptiness*—Burrough’s “space” (1986)—toward which the player travels, as explored in section 5.. My thesis is concerned with the movement toward nothingness that can only be observed in liminality. Although it is never possible to reach nothingness, one must see in liminality something that is “neither sterile nor futile” (Camus [1942] 2012, 168; my translation) to be satisfied with the different conclusions made throughout my thesis. However, to properly treat that topic, I should base my argumentation on existentialist theories, which leads us to an alternative reading of my thesis:

Existentialism owes its name to its emphasis on “existence”. ... [E]xistence indicates the special way in which human beings are in the world, in contrast with other beings. For the existentialists, the human being is “more” than what it is: not only does the human being know that it is but, on the basis of this fundamental knowledge, this being can choose how it will “use” its own being, and thus how it will relate to the world. “Existence” is thus closely related to freedom in the sense of an active engagement in the world. *This metaphysical theory regarding human freedom leads into a distinct approach to ontology, i.e., the study of the different ways of being.* (Deranty 2025, np; my emphasis)

I aim to construct an ontological explanation of players. Such a project is situated on two imbricated levels: the realms of existence and of explanation. I am thus obligated to do a ‘second-degree ontology’, i.e., the framing of my explanation outside of my player ontology. As such, if a being *is* through material, meaningful and social existence, I must explain them through other modes. I chose another tripartite approach: phenomenological, i.e., how one experiences things; fictional, i.e., what is framed by one’s phenomenological existence; and social metaphysical, regarding “the ontological natures of socially constructed groups, entities, and institutions” (van Inwagen et al. 2023, np), i.e., what frames one’s phenomenological existence within the boundaries of observable scientific study. The centrality of actual life—phenomenological experience—is due to its capacity to theorise both the fictional and the social metaphysical. A fictional existence cannot imagine another fiction or, rather, is limited to

the fictions that exist (Pavel 1986, 55). A social metaphysical existence cannot conceive a frame that surpasses itself because it is defined as “the general inquiry into the nature of entities” (Epstein 2024, np). Using the terms of my thesis, radical players are in between games’ fictional worlds and Empire.

This leads to the main alternative reading that Turner’s distinction between liminal and liminoid brings to my thesis: the radical players I attempt to make re-emerge are in between liminal and liminoid, for they are in between leisure and work, poetics and metaphysics, imaginary and real, the game and the sacred. They do so by building bridges that allow transportation between ontologically separated spheres. Through travelling, they show the potential transformations that one ontologically inferior sphere can operate on the superior one. On one hand, players’ relationships with the liminoid are observable when Gaston Bachelard ([1957] 1961) turns the miniature fictional world into his world, when *l’homme bus* (Etter 1983) turns his game into a full-time job, and when I turn a memorable friendship moment into academic work. On the other hand, players’ relationships with the liminal are made visible when Nora (1978) connects objective history and subjective narratives, Durkheimian sociology (cf. Caillois [1939] 1988; 1958; Durkheim [1912] 2005; Halbwachs [1925] 1976; Huizinga [1949] 1998⁶) connects the sacred to everyday life, and poststructuralist political philosophers (cf. Deleuze and Guattari 1980; Foucault 1980; Hardt and Negri 2000) connect totalising systems to an entity that is possible to subvert. Lastly, players’ relationships between both the fictional and the social metaphysical spheres are the clearest in works about myths (cf. Barthes [1957] 2005). These figures build up hope for Turner’s (1974, 75) utopian anti-structure, defined as:

the liberation of human capacities of cognition, affect, volition, creativity, etc., from the normative constraints incumbent upon occupying a sequence of social statuses, enacting a multiplicity of social roles, and being acutely conscious of membership in some corporate group such as a family, lineage, clan, tribe, or nation, or of affiliation with some pervasive social category such as a class, caste, sex- or age-division. (Turner 1974, 75)

It is similar to the hope found in Jiao’s (2024) conclusion about the transformative power of video games:

⁶ Huizinga does not directly cite Durkheim, but this filiation has already been established by Di Filippo (2014, 292).

The transformations resulting from liminoid experiences such as art and games may be subtler than those arising from true liminal events. However, they are nonetheless significant, embedding themselves in our subconsciousness and cumulatively synthesizing with the rich tapestry of our life experiences to continuously shape our identities, worldviews, and behaviors. (Jiao 2024, 476)

It is my hope that the transportation of social metaphysics into the actual world can cause the same transformations as when players are transported into game worlds, that players' creativity can ascend to social institutions. The existence of the radical player depends on this unreachable goal. *Despite this dead-end, radical players can hope* because they have shown that travel can be transformative. To paraphrase Camus ([1942] 2012, 168), one must see radical players happy.

1.3.3. *The Players' Hope*

In this section, I attempt to adapt Kant's ethical framework to my thesis to define the players' hope as the bottom-up transformation of an ontological realm by another.

Throughout the present thesis, the dominant phenomenological approach aims to form descriptions without passing judgment. However, like Rorty (1989), I aim to emerge a useful figure that should be perceived as moral, thus necessitating the inclusion of ethics in my framework. Although the radical players I define are not concerned with universal laws, the explanation I give, if convincing, must have a universal aim. My task is thus to find a theoretical framework that can morally define players. Kant's categorical imperative from *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals* ([1785] / 2009) constitutes a solid start for this task for the following reasons:

a) Players' existence is fluid, for they exist in two distinct, yet bridged, ontological spheres: the fictional and the actual. For the fictional, the world of make-believe, the actual constitutes its metaphysics, the outside world, the untouchable, the sacred life that constitutes the player as a person beyond the game. For the actual, the world of everyday life, institutions constitute the metaphysics, the unescapable game in which one has roles and goals imposed to play without possible distinction between a private and public identity. If the static consequences of what happens in the fictional and the actual world are not the same, the travel, the distance, and the difference between the fictional and the actual are similar enough to the one between the actual and the institutional. Therefore, the appropriate universalisation of the present thesis shall

determine *absolute values in the movement from one state to the other but not in any specific state*.

This principle is to be found in Kant's argumentation toward the first formulation of the categorical imperative: "I ought never to act except in such a way that I could also will that my maxim should become a universal law" (Kant [1785], 4:402 / 2009, 56). The argument is summarised by Guyer (2014) as follows:

- 1) A person has goodwill when she performs an action that is not only "*in conformity with duty*" (Kant [1785], 4:398 / 2009, 53; original emphasis), but by performing such an action "*from duty*" (Kant [1785], 4:398 / 2009, 53; original emphasis).
- 2) An action is judged because of its motivation rather than its outcome. Thus, it must lie "*in the principle of the will* without regard for the ends that can be brought about by such an action" (Kant [1785], 4:400 / 2009, 55; original emphasis)
- 3) "[D]uty is the necessity of an action from respect for law" rather than from any "*inclination*" for a state of affairs (Kant [1785], 4:400 / 2009, 55; original emphasis).

b) Players' existence is situated. The universalisation sought must not account for things beyond life. Players' existence is centralised around games, the tiniest unit of meaning. Ontologically, there is nothing under games, and there is nothing beyond institutions. Players do not exist beyond their actual lives as much as fictional characters do not exist beyond their fictional lives. That a thing cannot exist beyond its ontological boundaries does not mean that it cannot transform other things beyond it. Unlike Empire's or institutional universals, which exist beyond a human's life, players' universals must be contained within it—and this is where the explanation must place itself one step above the player's existence. As such, the term 'universal' in the present thesis, is Empire's universal, which goes beyond space and time as experienced by a human being, for it has no boundaries for conquest and memories, while the players' 'universal' is bounded by games and institutions, i.e., it is bounded by their very existence. The universal must be able to recognise the "person playing" (Carse 1986, 15) in every game they play and not the particular "role played" (ibid.).

Carse's principle that infinite players "regard each participant in finite play as that *person playing* and not as a *role played* by someone" (1986, 15) is here to be understood as a

player-reformulation of Kant's second formulation of the categorical imperative: "*So act that you use humanity, whether in your own person or in the person of any other, always at the same time as an end, never merely as a means*" ([1785] 4:429 / 2009, 80; original emphasis). A person, whether it is Kant's "rational being" or Carse's "infinite player", constitutes an

end that can be advanced by and only by adherence to [a] law. And if the law is to be unconditionally valid, as the moral law is supposed to be, then that end must be unconditionally valuable. (Guyer 2014, 212)

c) Players exist as a multiplicity. Players implicitly play a meta-game, a game outside the game, dictated by institutions. For players to be 'good', this meta-game, i.e., institutional reality, must restrict the possible games to the ones that let players recognise themselves not only as 'roles' but as 'persons playing'. This implies that players need to organise themselves collectively.

The universalisation of this principle proposed by Kant is made through the passage "from the principle of autonomy"(4:433 / 83) to "heteronomy"(ibid.). For that purpose he defines the concept of "*a kingdom of ends*" (ibid.; original emphasis), the "systematic union of various rational beings through common laws" (ibid.). This 'kingdom of ends' creates for people an ambivalent identity which Kant describes as follows:

A rational being belongs as a *member* to the kingdom of ends when he gives universal laws in it but is also himself subject to these laws. He belongs to it as *sovereign* when, as lawgiving, he is not subject to the will of any other. (Kant [1785], 4:433 / 2009, 83; original emphasis)

I reach here the limit of what I can universalise through players, for they cannot develop a consciousness that surpasses the institutions they live in. I must thus turn to historical periods where it has been possible for people to transform, as people, their institutions. This kind of universal, common laws that go against the established, stable institutions is best to be found in revolutionary events. Kant cannot provide a satisfactory argument for the transformation of the upper ontological sphere for he "argued that the state must be reformed 'from top to bottom', meaning that since reform must come through established legal channels, it is formally the task of the government" (Maliks 2022, 15). For Kant "[r]evolution is never justified because it lacks rightful authority" (Buchanan and Motchoulski 2023, np).

As a contemporary to Kant, I thus focus here on the ideals promoted by Robespierre, inspired by Rousseau, as a renewal of the old metaphysics, the dechristianization of France, and its replacement by the Cult of the Supreme Being defined as “the practice of human duties” (Robespierre 1794 cited in Guillemin 1987, 386). Robespierre always defended a moral ideal that was to accompany the Revolution and the institutions of the Republic. Although the decree on the worship of the supreme being appears at first sight to be the strongest symbol of this desire for a unifying morality, it is arguably in his *Réponse aux manifestes des rois ligués contre la République*⁷ (1793) that it is expressed most universally:

Your masters tell you that the French nation has proscribed all religions, that it has substituted the worship of a few men for that of the Divinity; they portray us in your eyes as idolatrous or foolish people. They are lying: the French people and their representatives respect the freedom of all worship and proscribe none. They honour the virtue of the martyrs of humanity without infatuation or idolatry; they abhor intolerance and persecution, whatever the pretext. They condemn the extravagances of philosophism as the follies of superstition and the crimes of fanaticism. Your tyrants impute to us certain irregularities inseparable from the stormy movements of a great revolution. They impute to us the effects of their own intrigues and the attacks of their emissaries. (Robespierre 1793, 6)

This protestation, translated into all languages (Mathiez 1910, 140), was written with a diplomatic aim: “to preserve for France the sympathies of the neutral countries” (ibid.). The three ideological sides he is fighting against, “philosophism”, “superstition”, and “fanatism”, are, respectively, the rationalism embodied by encyclopedists such as Condorcet (Guillemin 1987, 385) the undemocratic religious power embodied by the clergy (361), and the undistinctive persecution of clergy embodied by Cambon, a deputy of Robespierre’s political party (365). The “certain irregularities”, i.e., all transgressions of the law that accompanied the Revolution, are characteristic of a transformation operated from the actual to the institutional realm. These transgressions rely upon the same mechanisms as the ones operated by the institutions: they are, for instance, the organisation of wealth, violence and faith.

The establishment of a “State metaphysic” (Guillemin 1987, 386) confronted a strong political opposition, even from within Robespierre’s political party (356). It was his admiration for

⁷ “Answer to the manifests of the kings in league against the Republic”

Rousseau that led him to declare his belief in and conception of God as early as 1789 (Guillemin 1987, 351):

It is time that this idea of God, used for so long by adulation to give the rulers of empires unlimited and monstrous power, finally serves as a reminder of the imprescriptible rights of men; it is time to recognise that *the same divine authority that orders kings to be just forbids peoples to be slaves*. (Robespierre cited in Hampson 1974, 58; my emphasis)

This opposition can be seen as two directions, two forces opposed by an absolute and universal morality in a political struggle. It can be found either in the laws already established by a political regime, i.e. the laws that come from above, a ‘realm of ends’ targeted at the lower and that Kant advocates, or in revolutionary ideas, i.e., the laws that come from below and that Robespierre advocates. The opposition between players and Empire established in the present thesis tends to facilitate the re-emergence of the player’s *hope* that transformation from the lower to the upper ontological realm can occur, i.e., that if the fictional can transform the actual then the actual can transform the institutional. On the other side, the mechanisms of power defining Empire are related to the control of ontologically inferior realms, to force them to either conform to the imposed roles or cease their existence.

My conclusion echoes Rorty’s (1989) opposition between metaphysicians and ironists where the former “think that liberal political freedoms require some consensus about what is universally human” (84) and the latter “think that such freedoms require no consensus on any topic more basic than their own desirability” (ibid.). My players’ hope is close to the liberal ironists’ in the sense that it justifies dangerous transformation from the actual to the institutional, i.e., political struggle, in the name of a meta-game where it is possible for players to “regard each participant in finite play as that *person playing* and not as a *role played* by someone” (Carse 1986, 15), i.e., in the name of political freedom.

2. Framework motivation: Analysing Players vs Empire

2.1. Games are complex and ambiguous, theories need to be transparent about the conflict they study

The everyday relationship with video games questions the intuitive relationship between fiction and reality and what it means for something to exist. There is a responsibility that players assume mixed with a sense of spectating, and a seriousness imposed by life-threatening institutions that impose a certain relationship with everyday life. What I propose to study in my thesis is this double hierarchy of games and fiction, the one of video games where players experience different roles in the characters' fictional worlds, and the one of everyday life, where institutions ask one to play different roles in one's actual life. A complex framework of theories is necessary, one that must account for experience, extraordinary spaces, fiction and reality, existence, and institutional power relationships. This framework should also be flexible enough to account for the unstable characteristics of a player's experience, fluctuating between different worlds, goals, roles and even bodies. It should also account for the diversity of institutions and experiences, and how they interrelate to create a network of powers and subjectivities. Lastly, these theories should account for this diversity, not by finding an all-unifying category but by situating themselves through an explicit enunciation of their function, of the conflict, the power relationship, they are aiming to make re-appear through their framework. The result is a structure that is an intertwining of phenomenological and poststructuralist theories that function as reading frameworks for each other.

2.2. Completing the hermeneutic circle and determining a vanishing point

This framework is accepted as complete, cohesive and exhaustive when its function is attained and its hermeneutic circle is closed. The main function of my thesis is to give players a new definition that opposes them to stable and authoritarian forms of power. The opposition is not made through sociologically determined categories of people, although they play a role, but through a multitude of possible, chosen, and liberating experiences that are either fluid, multiple and situated or stable, uniform, and universal. The figure opposed to players, representing the stable forms of power, is Empire, not only in the sense of Hardt and Negri (2000) but as a

unifying and stabilising power, a linear system that has a singular relationship between itself and the world and tends to assimilate or annihilate otherness without boundaries. For my thesis to be complete, I need the figure of the player to be an individual through which the whole is made meaningful, and the whole should make it possible to find the individual to complete the hermeneutic circle (see Mantzavinos 2016).

The function of the thesis, its vanishing point, serves as the element that can be tested by the theories it is constituted by. The theories used to reach this vanishing point, the struggle between players and Empire are chosen to fit a double function. They should be intelligible in terms that are used to define a game, as “existing behind a boundary that transforms meaning” (Stenros 2017, 506), and so is my thesis, i.e., transforming the meaning of players through the proposed theoretical framework. Regrouped with this aim, the theories presented are both about creating a new definition of players and are understandable through the lens of players, understanding them as games. Players are both the starting and the end point of my thesis; they are defined by and allow one to define my theoretical framework.

2.3. My Super Framework

2.3.1. My theoretical metastructure: Fluidity, situatedness and multiplicity

Although the selected texts that serve as a basis for my argument come from a wide range of fields of studies—literature, political philosophy, phenomenology, cognitive sciences, history, linguistics, semiotics, ludology, and sociology—, they share transdisciplinary concepts that are useful to understand players better. The most important might be *fluidity*, used to describe the porous boundaries structuring the different categories. It concerns any taxonomy that is expressed in terms of spectra or that accepts ambivalent positions. Fluid theories allow the understanding of players controlling and being controlled by, shaping and being shaped by, both inside and outside games. They address, respectively, the negotiation of agency between the game and the player, the repartition of identity formation between the player’s actual and in-game body, and the characterisation of the player’s ontological presence in the game’s world. This triad of fluid categorisation of player has been established by Schallegger for defining

games (2017, 43) as the system dynamics (agency), the avatar's function (identity), and the player's experience (ontological liminality).

Table 2: The Three Fluid Characteristics of the Players and Games

Players' Ambivalent Position	Schallegger's Taxonomy of Games	Associated Thematic
Controlling a game designed to control the player	System dynamics	Agency
Shaping and taking the identity of the game through embodied interactions	Avatar function	Identity
The play space is constituted of the player's actual environment and of the game's fictional world	Player experience	Ontological Liminality

Rather than analysing states and positions, these theories allow an analysis of movement and dynamics between different states. Fluid theories aim to position themselves in between pre-existing theories, being both and neither at the same time. The theories of metalepsis (Alber 2013; Bell 2016; Bell and Alber 2012; Genette 1966; 2004; Ryan 2004; Wolf 2013), ontological flickering (Bell 2019), double situatedness (Ensslin 2011), distance (Henriot 1976, Pavel 1986), and the sacred (Caillois [1939] 1988; 1958; Durkheim [1912] 2005; Huizinga [1949] 1998), coming from sociology, literature and game studies, are best suited to explore the player's ambivalent positions. They account for the multiplicity of identities and meanings a thing can have at the same time or go through, making them particularly well designed for non-linear conceptions of time.

The second concept is *situatedness*, an ambition to see things without their embedded cultural meaning, necessitating a consciousness of the meaning's artificiality and a belief in nothingness. The concept comes from phenomenology, especially in Husserl (1931) and Merleau-Ponty (1945), but is found in all the works from the disciplines mentioned above that aim to situate their research explicitly, for instance in Nora's works on sites of memory (1978; 1984) and Foucault's genealogies of madness and psychiatric institutions (1972), the psycho-legal expertise

(1999), or neoliberalism and biopower (2004). This is not idealism because it does not consist in isolating an element to understand its pure or absolute version. On the contrary, it is to understand the general system that gives this element its meaning. A thing always exists in relation to something else, whether the relation is negative or positive. The player can only exist because there are games, and games can only exist because there are non-games. In short, it is to recognise the impossibility of understanding a thing in particular, to focus on the understandable general system to which it belongs. This concept is useful to explore the ways players can reappropriate reality and the ways they reassign values, function and roles by creating new systems, i.e., games. The combination of fluidity and situatedness can be expressed through the metaphors of breathing, intertwining, or chiasma (see Merleau-Ponty 1945), depicting a symbiosis, an organic interdependency, between a thing and another. In the case of players, it is often expressed with the feedback loop of the cyborg, the human-machine system (Salen and Zimmerman 2004, 141; Dovey and Kennedy 2006, 109).

Lastly, the selected theories give an important place to *multiplicity*, expressed as “the myriad of bodies” (Foucault 1980, 98), the ‘multitude’ (Hardt and Negri 2000), “intersubjectivity” (Merleau-Ponty 1945), or “the histories” (Nora 1978, 400). They all account for the diversity and complexity of individuals, keeping them out of stable and permeable categories. The diversity of players in their games, roles, desires and cultural backgrounds requires their analysis through multiplicity to preserve a non-normative approach. Ultimately the three concepts of fluidity, situatedness and multiplicity are general enough to examine works that ground themselves in the world, the self, and the other, aiming to better understand them, believing in their immanent existence as much as in the existence of nothingness. Implicitly, the theories’ unification stems from an interest in the affective, kinesthetic, memorial, and imaginal aspects of players, which are closely related to Merleau-Ponty’s works (see Mazis 2016, xii), making *Phénoménologie de la Perception* (1945) the key work for my thesis.

2.3.2. Poststructuralist methodology

Producing knowledge with this eclectic bibliographical corpus entails a poststructuralist methodology. The term ‘poststructuralism’ is used to describe the work of an ensemble of

thinkers who are widespread in backgrounds and disciplines but united by their will of detachment from structuralism. Structuralism operates in a fairly straightforward way: it sets about schematising the object of its analysis by breaking it down into actors, functions and values. The result of a structuralist analysis is a system of binary categories that can be used to identify the role of a cultural object in a system. In contrast, poststructuralism is about abandoning universal ambition in favour of a conception of the result of analysis as situated knowledge. The poststructuralist production of knowledge aims for what Deleuze and Guattari (1980) call “assemblages” (*agencements*) (10), “a relatively stable connexion between heterogenous terms which, nevertheless, contain lines of deterritorialisation through which novelty can be produced in these terms” (David-Ménard 2008, 44; my translation). Assemblage is a tool to analyse enunciated elements as *meaningful because they are part of an evolving system*, “an ongoing process rather than a static situation” (Buchanan 2015, 383).

Post-structuralist work will therefore favour multidisciplinary approaches in search of an innovative application, i.e., a new combination of discipline and object of study. This can lead to some surprising outcomes, such as the theories of literary analysis proposed by Moretti (2005) using a historical, geographical and evolutionary approach applied to literature. Still in Deleuze and Guattari’s terminology, these innovative research endeavors constitute reterritorialisation and thus the finding of new meanings. A territory defines the elements’ hierarchical relationships in a system organised in binaries. To give a quite literal example, to be Moroccan in France is different from being a Moroccan in Morocco in terms of history, language, or rights. To move beyond the binary category systems established by structuralist analysis, post-structuralists combine systems and deconstruct them.

Combinations are not simply additions of knowledge from one discipline and another but produce new knowledge at the intersection of these disciplines. Consequently, they produce more accurate analyses in that they represent a more complete reality rather than an isolated, abstract element that is more alien to lived reality. This approach to knowledge can be found in intersectional studies (see Hill Collins 2020) and the cognitive sciences (Newen, Bruin, and Gallagher 2018). Deconstruction, for its part, is the method by which post-structuralists attempt to emancipate themselves from the binary categorisations that make it possible to account for the contradictions inherent in the very principle of theorisation (Gödel 1931). Derrida defines the

method in two steps: first, a hierarchical inversion of a binary and then its annihilation (1972, 57). A post-Marxist approach to the history of production reverses the hegemonic hierarchy between the bourgeoisie and the working class, understood as part of a larger domination system, and the effective power reversal leads to a classless society while acknowledging the necessary creation of new binaries.

Since the result of a structuralist analysis claims to be a universal matrix, there would be little point in establishing it if its power were weaker than the objects it frames. Thus, while structuralism advocates a two-way influence between the structure and its products—or the basis and the superstructure—with a preference for the influences of the structure, post-structuralism takes care to position its objects of study not as active or passive, product or producer, but as necessary to the functioning of the whole system. In Deleuze and Guattari's terms, a system is to be understood as a *rhizome* rather than an arborescence, with its elements being all interconnected, without basis and superstructure (1980, 13). A post-structuralist study thus begins with an understanding of a system as a whole, the limits of which are given by its situation, and all the elements of which are equal insofar as they are necessary to it. An element only makes sense within a system, and a system only makes sense with all its elements. The stated differences between structuralism and post-structuralism are summarised in the following table:

Table 3: Comparison between Structuralism and Post-Structuralism

Characteristic	Structuralism	Post-Structuralism
Aimed scale of produced knowledge	Universal	Situated
Methodology	Unity of the field of studies and its relation to the object of studies	Multidisciplinary approach; innovative for its study objects
Functions of a system's elements	Binary: understanding of the scale of the element	Necessary: understanding of the scale of the system

2.3.3. *Nora's poststructuralist history*

In his article on collective memory (1978), Nora gives the building blocks for a post-structuralist history. Through the distinction between historical memory and collective memory, he offers an analysis of the evolution of historiography in several stages. First, in making the history of history, he observes that the historians of the classical tradition wrote intending to construct “for an identifiable group the genealogy of its legitimacy” (399; my translation), bringing them closer to the function of myth-makers than critical historians. This tradition includes accounts of Greek and Roman wars, the myth of the city, the Carolingian legend, the good times of one king or another and the Aryan myth (399). These stories therefore move from history, in the sense of historical facts, towards memory. These texts have a political vocation and their scientific qualities are relegated to second place. As the examples cited illustrate, these stories serve imperial narratives and are therefore intended to be universal. It is from these elements that Nora constructs his definition of collective memory as “globalising and borderless, blurred and telescoping, [pertaining] to a belief that assimilates only what supports itself” (399).

The second development is the upheaval in the relationship between history and memory. While traditional history, or rather traditional mythical narratives, were the source of collective memory, Nora observes that this relationship has been reversed in his time, meaning that memory influences history (400). There are two reasons for this phenomenon. The first is the diversification and proliferation of collective memories due to the intensification of social and economic ruptures in contemporary societies (*ibid.*). The second reason is the massification and immediacy of the means of information that form a so-called ‘immediate’ history, informed by events from a perspective with a unique, unstable and contradictory temporality (*ibid.*). This development implies a transformation of the discipline of history into a discipline of histories as a “field of ideological forces” (*ibid.*).

Historical memory is Nora's response to these developments, a history that studies memory ‘analytically and critically, precisely and distinctly, as a matter of reason that instructs without convincing’ (399). It has its roots in Durkheimian sociology, philosophy, psychoanalysis and literature. It is the transformation of ‘problem history’ into ‘narrative history’. For section 6.4 tracing Empire’s and players’ genealogy of nostalgia, I follow the historical methodology proposed by Nora through the three following points:

- 1) The adoption of an openly contemporary problematic [...] of a resolutely retrospective approach, whose fragmented curiosities respond to the social demand of all the social groups involved in the historical process.
- 2) The renunciation of a linear temporality; inhabited by a mechanistic causality; in favour of a deliberately ethnological, or anthropological, point of view, which focuses attention on the levels where the individual is immediately rooted in the social and the collective: linguistic and demographical, biological, economic, metaphysical or cultural levels.
- 3) The replacement of one privileged period, Antiquity and the Middle Ages, this time of 'origins' by another privileged period, this 'modern' period which is neither quite ours nor quite another, three or four centuries rich in quantitative sources to which our own societies, those we are still trying to understand, are directly linked. (Nora 1978, 400; my translation)

2.3.4. *Mentioning Games of Empire*

The present thesis inscribes itself in the legacy of *Games of Empire* (hereafter GoE) (Dyer-Witheford and De Peuter 2009), and, as its title indicates, this book is rooted both in game studies and in *Empire* (Hardt and Negri 2000), itself stemming from Italian Marxist theories and French Theory. GoE demonstrates how every aspect of video games, from their creation, through their content, their use and subversion, is an incarnation of Empire, with the intent to describe and criticise Empire. Although GoE explores players' behaviours, its main concern is video games, not players, for they are primarily described as reacting to the games and their industry. My aim here is to delve into the philosophical and sociological—or rather philosophical grounds for sociological work—approaches to players to place them not as a reaction to Empire but as an already-there alternative. To paraphrase Foucault's work on subjugated knowledge (1980, 82), it is through the reappearance of the player as a subjugated mode of existence, from their ontological conflict against Empire, that criticism can perform its work⁸. Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology serves as a starting point for this alternative criticism of Empire, because it gives a broad and flexible enough matrix of analysis from which I can give a new meaning to players and Empire.

⁸ The exact quote is the following: "it is through the re-appearance of this knowledge, of these local popular knowledges, these disqualified knowledges, that criticism performs its work." (Foucault 1980, 82)

3. Merleau-Ponty's Phenomenology

3.1. *Definition of phenomenology*

So what do we have at the beginning? Not a multiple given with a synthetic apperception which travels and crosses it from part to part, but a certain perceptive field on a world background. Nothing here is thematised. Neither the object nor the subject is set. One does not have in the origin field a mosaic of qualities, but a total configuration that distributes the functional values according to the ensemble's exigence, and, for example, as we have seen, a 'white' paper in the shadow is not white in the sense of objective quality, but it is worth as white. (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 279; my translation)

Phenomenology deconstructs the object-subject dualism in human existence. Being cannot be understood alone but only in combination with other things. In other words, one cannot be an absolute being but is always a being-in or a being-with something. This thought stems from the relativisation of the primacy of the mind, in the Cartesian *cogito*, and the relativisation of the primacy of the material objects, as found in empirical philosophy, in favour of a primacy of perception. In the Cartesian *cogito*, the human being is positioned as a subject of thinking, whereas in empirical philosophy, it is considered as a scientifically explainable object. Phenomenology, and later cognitive sciences, look for the interactions between body, mind, and world without presupposing causal relationships but instead understanding them as a whole. With the primacy of perception, the meanings given to existence are taken as a whole, for humans cannot perceive a part of a system without everything it is related to (Merleau Ponty 1945; Matthews 2006, 26). In this sense, the understanding of a thing as being solely an object or subject of a system only exists after a reflective phase, and thus after perception. Perception, as the process of meaning-making, is necessarily the perception of a whole, without the distinction between object and subject.

The dissolution of object and subject stems from the embeddedness of a conscious being understood through the phenomenological concept of intentionality. The intentionality of consciousness was coined by Husserl (1931), where intentionality signifies that consciousness cannot be understood in the absolute but is necessarily the consciousness *of* something (Schmidt 1985, 23). Merleau-Ponty's reading of Husserl relates an 'operative' intentionality

that which makes up the natural and antepredicative unity of the world and our life, which appears in our desires, our evaluations, our landscape [, i.e., our subjective experience], more clearly than in objective knowledge, and which provides the text of which our knowledge seeks to be the translation into exact language. (Merleau-Ponty 1945, xiii; my translation)

The primacy of perception appears here as the basis for knowledge; objective knowledge can be produced from the interpretation of one's subjective experience of the world. In other words, the only true world out there that is possible to understand is the one in which our subjectivity is embedded. This is related to the concept of being-in-the-world, *Inderweltsein*, coined by Heidegger ([1927] 2007), which situates one's existence as embedded in the world because of one's consciousness of being part of it.

More particularly than the world, consciousness is embedded in a body to which Merleau-Ponty dedicates the first part of his *Phénoménologie de la Perception* (1945), a massive influence on the later field of cognitive sciences (Depraz and Gallagher 2002). The phenomenological body is the source and expression of consciousness, distinct from the objective biological body. The latter is how medical sciences conceive of the body, as a machine, a system with functions related to each other by causal relationships, with a normal and abnormal functioning state. The phenomenological body allows for a definition of consciousness that is not hidden, ungraspable and central to human beings. Merleau-Ponty is opposed to the centrality of consciousness supported by Brunschvicg and the philosophy of consciousness (Schmidt 1985). He replaces the terms belonging to the lexical field of ideas with terms that are proper for the descriptions of structures as wholes “which neither give primacy to the standpoint of consciousness nor rest on a distinction between subject and object” (Schmidt 1985, 8). Terms like “concept, idea, mind, representations” become “dimensions, articulations, levels, hinges, pivots, configurations” (ibid.). This shift of consciousness to embodied consciousness stems from the centrality of meaning-making in Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology. Arguably his main axiom considering human existence is that “[b]ecause we are in the world, we are condemned to meaning, and we cannot do nor say anything which does not take a name in history” (1945, xiv-xv; my translation). It is from the fact that a living being “projects himself the norms of his milieu and poses himself the terms of his vital problem” (ibid., 93; my translation), that subjectivity and thus meaning-making exist. In other words, it is the intentional embodied existence that structures the world as goals and obstacles.

To transcend the object-subject dichotomy, proper to scientific thinking, Merleau-Ponty proposes to go back to things themselves, *les choses mêmes*, as a way of describing factual experience. He defines this process as “to go back to this world before the knowledge from which knowledge always speaks, and regarding which all scientific determination is abstract, signitive and dependent” (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 14; my translation), adapted from Husserl’s eidetic analysis. The

eidetic analysis is an a posteriori clarification of concrete, factual experience [...] understood as a technique of enabling reflection to grasp the pre-reflective life of an incarnate consciousness; it is the means by which ‘our effective involvement in the world’ is brought to conceptualisation. (Schmidt 1985, 40)

In other words, phenomenology takes into account the arbitrary aspect of scientific knowledge, the intelligible explanation, to make possible the description of one’s experience before the explanation. However it is not a total de-situation of the thinker, put in a vacuum, but a focused doubt that acknowledges the existence of everything else but the doubted thing. To go back to things themselves is to reach the pre-reflective state, an essential part of phenomenology’s methodology, as the bracketing of the natural standpoint.

Before delving into the ‘bracketing of existence’ it is important to understand its distinction from the previous philosophical doubts. Schmidt (1985, 20) traces the genealogy of the phenomenological doubt from Descartes through Husserl to Merleau Ponty, with each author reading the previous one in a “creative way” (ibid.). For Husserl, Descartes’s *cogito* fails to correctly define science because the latter sees in science the way to understand the world in pure physical bodies (ibid.). Consequently, Husserl renames Descartes’s science as ‘objective sciences’ and states that the only condition for knowledge to be scientific is that it relies upon evidence-based causal relationships (ibid., 21; Matthews 2006). Husserl’s understanding of the role of science leads to a doubt that is not only about how human senses distort the reality of the material world but also scientific thinking. In his turn, Merleau-Ponty refuses an absolute radical doubt through his distinction between illusions and perception because to doubt every appearance would mean that they are either all true or all false (1945, 340). Perception relies on doubting something and not doubting all the others. For one to be able to doubt something, one has to believe in the world as a whole (ibid., 345; Matthews 2006, 43).

With this statement, Merleau-Ponty situates himself neither in a philosophy that “only accounts for truth and perception” (1945, 341) nor in the philosophy of the absurd that “only accounts for illusion or error” (ibid.), because the belief that the world as a whole exists implies that both perception and illusion exist. “There is absolute certainty of the world in general, but none of anything in particular” (344). Descartes casts doubt on the capacity of our senses to understand the material world, and certainty on the scientific method. Husserl casts doubt on the scientific method. And Merleau-Ponty allows doubt on every particular thing based on a general belief in the existence of the world as a whole. Phenomenology grounds itself in the conception of a natural standpoint (Husserl 1931), the common scientific understanding of the world as an objective thing, that exists independently from our subjectivities whereas the primacy of perception is responsible for meaning-making. One consequence of this statement is that there is a relativisation of the role of scientific knowledge, which is not directly a tool for meaning-making, but rather the analysis of causal relationships within a system to make it intelligible. In simpler terms, a thing needs to be understood before being possibly intelligible and explained through reflection. Bracketing the natural standpoint is to make it as if the explanation was wrong, leading one to doubt the theoretical understanding of experience and thus focus on experience. It is important to underline that the ‘things themselves’ are not transcendental, ungraspable but true identities of things, on the contrary, they are the basis of reality as one can experience them.

This theoretical background frames my definition of players through their phenomenological existence. It helps build a theory in which players do not need to be conscious of the aspects that define them for them to exist. That their consciousness is not central does not mean that they are unconscious beings, considered as objects, but that they are both object *and* subject, meaning that their existence is always situated. To define such an existence requires theories that can account for instability, situatedness and multiplicity. Player consciousness is indeed central to the act of playing, as the only difference between make-believe, or fictional experience, and real experience is consciousness. The following paragraphs detail the second step in my research, focusing on the question of fictionality of the experience.

3.2. *Imaginary perception*

For Merleau-Ponty, perception does not limit itself to the sensual experience but also includes imagination. Mazis (2016) retraces Merleau-Ponty's reflection on the imaginary, adapting it to the concept of the 'imaginal', an ambiguous place between the imaginary and the real. Three steps can be distinguished in Merleau-Ponty's reflection: first, the boundary between what is considered imaginary and real is not clear and distinct; second, the space regrouping the two is the mythical space where form and content make one; third, that people inhabit these spaces through make-believe to open their perception to otherness. Ultimately, Mazis states that the function of the imaginal is to make it possible for one to express oneself and to love another. I argue that, for players, these three steps are interdependent meaning-making processes of the world, the self and the other. The processes are analysed through theories about the narrative experience of players, in two movements, one from reality to fiction, theorised as fictionalisation (Bell 2019), myth-making (Barthes [1957] 2005), or miniaturisation (Bachelard [1957] 1961), the other from fiction to reality, theorised as naturalisation (Wolf 2013), narrativization (Fludernik 1996), or the activity of the mythologist (Barthes [1957] 2005). The players' breathing in a play world between reality and fiction, natural and unnatural, the understandable and the meaningless, is the presence of the player in the myth and as the expression of the myth, meaning the presence of the players for each other. It is the activity of the myth reader (Barthes [1957] 2005), or more generally, play (Huizinga [1949] 1998; Caillois [1939] 1988; 1958; Carse 1986; Nitsche 2008).

4. Defining Empire and Players

4.1. *Empire*

Empire is a post-Marxist concept coined by Hardt and Negri in *Empire* (2000) to define the hegemonic borderless biopolitical system of the postmodern era. It can be considered as an update of the modern analysis of imperial states in the globalised world, after the weakening of the centralised state-nation authority. Its main inspirations are the study of biopower and governmentality regimes by Foucault, the Machine of production described by Deleuze and

Guattari, and Italian Marxist texts (Hardt and Negri 2000, 28). Opposite to, and included in Empire, is the *multitude* (Hardt and Negri 2000, 47), the workers of Empire, defined by their desire, creation, and production, their immaterial and material labour. They are the motor of biopolitical production. Central to the concept of Empire, the study of biopower implies an immense scope as it is the study of power on life itself, its organisation and reproduction. Although my main reference for defining Empire are Hardt and Negri, because of my thesis's aforementioned theoretical framing, my definition of Empire strays away from the original to focus on its stability, universality and uniformity, i.e., its opposition to the players. Power is both transported by and forming individuals (Foucault 1980, 98), its study should not be concerned with a central authority imposing power on its subjects, but rather the constellation of domination forms, or, in Foucault's words, "not the uniform edifice of sovereignty, but the multiple forms of subjugation that have a place and function within the social organism" (96). Through this understanding of power, Empire is embodied through all the individuals who reproduce the pre-existing power structures.

In the following paragraph, I first define the terms *authority* and *domination* and how they function under Empire, i.e., as globalised and networked. I then focus on the notion of power, how it serves biopolitical production, especially in the form of truth.

4.1.1. Authority and domination under Empire

Empire's authority over the multitude is global and therefore requires an explanation of the different layers of domination in society. Weber defines domination as "the probability that certain specific commands (or all commands) will be obeyed by a given group of persons" (1978, 212). A domination relationship implies a social group that exercises dominion over another that is submitted to it. In a modern society context, these groups can be analysed from diverse perspectives: for example, they can be economical (Marx 1929), analysing the bourgeoisie's domination over the proletariat; gender-based (Bourdieu 2001), analysing masculine domination over the feminine; or race-based (Fanon 1961), analysing the domination of the white coloniser over the black colonised. Through deconstruction (Derrida 1972), postmodern approaches explore the subversion of the aforementioned binaries as well as the identities created by their intersection (cf. Hill Collins and Bilge 2020). The analysis of the

construction of these social structures, defined by a multitude of domination relationships, is the study of biopolitical production (Hardt and Negri 2000, xiii). From this perspective, all social groups have a production function in Empire, which is the postmodern global authority and system of production (Hardt and Negri 2000, 9). The groups are the *multitude* (Hardt and Negri 2000, 47), a theoretical concept defining all people who produce for Empire and who are submitted to its control but also “reveal an alternative ontological basis” (ibid.).

Although Empire is a unifying concept for all dominant groups, postmodern society does not have a centralised authority in the form of nation-states anymore (Hardt and Negri 2000, xii). In this sense, Empire’s authority is a network of authorities representing different forms of legitimisation. A power structure is to be understood as a system with rules and actors whose discourses define their function as political forces. In other words, it is creating a group’s hegemony, what Gramsci defines as the third moment in the relation of political forces (Gramsci 1994, 216). The rules are defined by institutions that direct the actor’s power, as political groups are part of a domination structure and determine their function in the system. In a parliamentary regime, political groups “participate in legislation and administration, even to reform these – but within the existing fundamental structures” (ibid.). For instance, in a capitalist structure of domination, the bourgeoisie exercises its authority over the proletariat, making power structures favourable for the former. The fact that a power structure is favourable to one political group with “economic and political aims [...], intellectual and moral unity [..., and] posing all the questions around which the struggles rage not on a corporate but on a ‘universal’ plane” (ibid.) is the source of hegemony. Thus, power structures are materialised through institutions, as materialised forms of authority, and regulate a power relationship between two groups.

4.1.2. The Function of Truth as Power in Biopolitical Production

Empire’s power structures determine the value of and organise biopolitical production, meaning the product of the multitude’s labour. With the growth of immaterial labour, especially in the field of video games (Dyer-Witheford and De Peuter 2009, xxix), power structures demand to be analysed through the concepts of “knowledge, communication and language” (Hardt and Negri 2000, 29)—which justifies that the main theories for this master’s thesis come from the fields of philosophy, media studies and linguistics, with particular attention to post-structuralist authors.

To determine the value of a product is to give objective meaning to it, which can create conflicts between multiple subjectivities, thus creating a power relationship. ‘Nostalgia’ has a different meaning in the discourse of medical dictionaries, literary analysis, and players, for example. This conflict between different actors is the source of a power relationship, inscribed in a power structure which determines the definitions of nostalgia’s truth value. It is possible to observe the repartition of power to different groups, and thus the domination relationship, through the analysis of power structures’ value distribution.

My thesis mainly focuses on truth as a form of power maintained by structures that define legitimate knowledge and establish a truth regime (cf. Foucault 1980). Institutions can be analysed through their discourse. For example, the French imperial medical institutions of the 19th century were part of the power structure that regulated whether some knowledge was part of legitimate medical knowledge and thus of the regime of truth of that time and place. The other way around, it is through the production of medical discourse that a form of domination can be exercised through the rational authority of the medical institution as part of the power structure of knowledge. Legitimate discourse is not only an ideological concept, it plays a material role because it is part of biopower.

The works of Foucault on medical (1972), psycho-legal (1999), and economical (2004) discourses are all concerned with the authority over the bodies and material conditions of a population. These works, and especially *Abnormal* (2003), depict the normative power of French governments that includes a population, opposite to a negative power of exclusion. Foucault describes “two major models for the control of individuals in the West: one is the exclusion of lepers and the other is *the model of the inclusion of plague victims*” (Foucault 2003, 44; my emphasis). The latter requires governments to control the population, i.e., to identify, list, group, examine, and cure, necessitating the development of authoritarian methods and institutions. To ground its legitimacy, the pieces of information collected for the control of individuals enable the establishment of a norm. By creating a norm, Empire can exercise its hegemony without having to question the domination binaries it implies. The abnormal is legitimately disciplined to become normal, meaning that the abnormal should become part of the biopolitical production. Authorities of normative power are rooted in the creation of political groups and their domination structures, meaning that the creation of a norm will necessarily imply the formation

of two opposite political groups: one *in* the norm and one *outside* the norm. In this sense, the dominant political groups of Empire have a hegemonic position that is predetermined by its normative discourse.

The only way to question the domination binaries of Empire is to consider them outside of normative structures, which necessitates being aware of legitimate, normative discourses and their effects. Legitimate discourses are thus an analysable part of the normalising power of Empire because Empire's goal is global biopolitical production. The kind of analysis that aims to decipher the norms, or values, produced by a discourse through an analysis of the binaries present can be found in Barthes' *Mythologies* ([1957] 2005). All the aforementioned characteristics of Empire are a demystification, or rather demystification of Empire because its discourse appears normal, mythified, and undoubted. Empire is thus not only understood as a biopolitical system of production but also as a narrative one. Furthermore, it is not only narrative in the sense that it can have a founding myth but an all-encompassing explanation for reality.

This is where our definition of the player can also find an initial moment, as an alternative type of claim on time, space and truth. The relationship between Empire and the players has mostly been described as the former invading and controlling the latter. In GoE, every aspect of the video game player is infected by Empire, for instance, the creation of games, the games themselves, the gaming machines, or the communities' behaviours. The players can only resist through traditional modes of action, hacking, modding, creating alternative games, avant-garde, cheating, stealing, in brief, everything that the oppressed can do against the oppressor. In this view, games are the battlefield for the struggle between Empire and players. By shifting the focus of struggle from game to *play*, it is possible to see how incompatible Empire and games are.

4.2. Definitions of play

Based on the definitions of Huizinga ([1949] 1998), Caillois (1958), and Suits (1978) I can establish the following definition of play:

Play is an activity that is (1) voluntary, (2) extraordinary—i.e. existing in a finite time and space separated from ordinary life—and (3) autotelic—meaning that what is produced in the game is strictly used for the game—where (4) the means (eventually formulated as rules) justify the goal and (5) create an experience based on make-believe.

The conflict exists when a characteristic of the play space is denied and can be listed as follows:

Table 4: The oppression of play by Empire

Play Characteristic	Denied existence under Empire	Empire Characteristic
Voluntary	Domination	Power to make an order executed
Autotelic	Exploitation	Use of someone's activity outside of their control
Extraordinary	Fascism	Assimilation/Annihilation of Otherness
The means justify the goal	Alienation	Disconnection of the means of experience from experience
Meaningful experience based on make-believe	Dogmatic belief	Establishing a truth regime

The multiple meaning of *imperium* emerge from this table as defined in the *Oxford Latin Dictionary*: “[t]he supreme administrative power... supreme authority in any sphere ... exercise of authority, rule, discipline ... command, bidding ... orders” (Glare 1968, 843-844), as well as the meaning of *imperator* as “[o]ne who gives orders, a person in charge” (ibid., 842).

Players are ontologically an alternative to Empire, meaning that their definition entails an entity that is fluid, situated and multiple. Empire is stable, universal and unique. This of course does not mean to play from time to time, or even being a professional player, rather, it is to choose an existence made meaningful through play, close to what Carse (1986) calls an Infinite Player, and what I call a radical player because of its political implications. Such players aim to play games because their meaningful existence depends on it. This proposition is not prescriptive but

descriptive; it aims to develop a criticism of Empire from a game studies perspective without advocating for a player's Empire. The replacement of the hegemony of Empire by the hegemony of the player would imply a possibility to think outside of Empire, and for the writer a possibility to annihilate their situation, or, as Burroughs puts it, it would require the writer to "travel in space" (1986, 149), like *Watchmen*'s Dr Manhattan (Moore and Gibbons 1986).

5. Play as travelling

5.1. Bridge between literary and game studies: playing texts

The relationship to fiction in other activities than play is often intuitively conceived as passive. Through a media studies lens, the author has the role of a sender and the reader of a receiver (cf. Jakobson 1960). The author creates and the reader consumes. This understanding of reading is subverted by poststructuralist literary theories. In *From Work to Text* (1979), Barthes argues that the reader's experience of literature is similar to the one of a musician reading and playing a score (79), the reader transforms a work, the literary object—the yet-to-be meaningful succession of sentences—into a text, which is the product of a reading, the creation of meaning. Reading is a potential for expressivity; through the actualisation, the repetition, and the deformation of a work, the reader creates a text. The function of such a theory is to subvert the hierarchy in the producer/consumer binary, which has been most iconically reversed in the *Death of the Author* (Barthes [1967] 1977), and Foucault's following answer ([1969] 2001). Not only putting the hierarchy upside down, it is a movement that dissolves power, not taking the author for the origin but each reading as such. Literary theories that focus on the *reader's* experience are adaptable to a game studies approach to fiction. Concepts describing the interpretation of narratives, or the movement between actual and fictional worlds are thus reused and applied to games and players throughout this thesis.

Like a game, a work of fiction can be analysed as a fictional space made available to a reader. The question of being transported to the fictional space is further analysed in section 5.2..

5.2. *Between reality and fiction*

To study the relationship between reality and fiction, different theories draw the boundary between the two changes what counts as play or not. There is a spectrum of theories about the experience of fiction, from the totalisation of reality into fiction, or representation, as in Goffman's (1956) and Baudrillard's (1981) work, but also in Suits (1978) where make believe is also an everyday game, or Carse (1986) where the boundaries of the game are played with by infinite players, guiding their lives like a spirituality. This set of theories allows one to explore reality through a game studies lens, i.e., everyday life as a game. It reveals itself as particularly useful for Empire's side of my analyses. At the other end of the spectrum, one finds the theories about the extraordinary spaces, meaning that fiction is separated from everyday life by a 'magic circle', a term coined by Huizinga ([1949] 1998, 20) to express that the border delimiting the game space cannot be distinguished from the Durkheimian boundary separating the sacred from the profane. This whole spectrum of theories reflects multiple approaches to Merleau-Ponty's mythical space; one accepts everyday life as constituted of myths, accentuating the openness and permeability of the mythical consciousness (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 338); the other accepts the ontological difference between fiction and reality, which does not mean that the boundary is the same for everyone but that there *is* a clearly enunciable one. The movement from one end of the spectrum to the other can be described through the theories of ontological metalepsis (Bell and Alber 2012) and magical realism (Thiem 1995), the contamination of one world by another. Transport is also described by theories of make-believe where it is not the world that is fluid, but the identity of the player who immerses herself through make-believe games.

In Pavel's terminology (1986), these connected worlds are clustered in a universe. Briefly summarised, Pavel's modal theory is built with universes *U*, composed of a set of worlds *K*, one of them being the actual world, a base to which the universe is anchored, and the others possible worlds, linked to each other with different conceptions of possibility *R* (51). A universe can be explained through language by regrouping all statements that are true about this universe, the *Magnum Opus* of the universe (52), into two categories: the foundational ones, the ones about the universe's actual world, the First Book (52), and the systemic ones, which limit what worlds possibly exist in this universe, the Book of Rules(52). Because of the singularity of interpretation, the same universe can have multiple *Magna Opera*, and the same *Magnum Opus*

can describe multiple universes. When a universe is based on the sacred, something that by definition cannot be fully grasped by human understanding, it is not possible to construct an associated *Magnum Opus*.

Universes are declined in flat and complex structures. A flat structure is constituted of a simple universe deprived of any alternative or fictional world, they are one unique actual world:

Seen from an external perspective, a flat structure is therefore a model representing the attitude of a population entirely deprived of the faculty of imagination. As things stand, a population deprived of imagination is but one person's fantasy in a population endowed with imagination. (Pavel 1986, 55)

Complex structures are built as the opposite of flat ones, meaning that alternative, fictional, possible worlds exist and their universes can be linked together through a Book of Correspondence (56), a sort of look-up table which defines everything from one universe with the terms of the other. A situated perspective cannot put forward an absolute judgement of truth for a world but can only establish relationships with situated hierarchies between them. As Pavel (1986) argues, the border between reality and fiction is not universal (76). The same fiction can take on multiple understandings across cultures, it can be religious, historical or mythical, depending on their truth value. To work on the border of fiction is to work on the truth value of a narrative.

On the non-fictional side of narratives, there are quantities of theories that apply terms usually used for fiction to real-world activities. The closest to play are Carse's (1986) Infinite Players and Suit's (1978) figure of the spy and the bore. In Carse's (1986) case, to be an infinite player is a spirituality, for it occurs outside a single world (91), through which one can approach every situation in life where the goal is to play and not to win (7), meaning that experiences are more meaningful than outcomes, for "[t]he joyfulness of infinite play, its laughter, lies in learning how to start something we cannot finish" (26). Suits describes the two figures of the spy and the bore as needing a situation to play their make-believe games: the spy plays roles that are inappropriate to their personality and the bore roles that are inappropriate to the situation. They can be the understanding of social interactions as performances, a make-believe game of everyday life, as in Goffman (1956) or Baudrillard (1981) where the social self is always a representation, a performance, an everyday life fictionalisation of a self. Nora's work on collective memory

provides an approach to history where historians use objects of the past to create a narrative history (1978); they play with objects of the past.

5.3. Caillois's distinction between games, the sacred, and everyday life

The division between fiction and reality can be expressed as border, frontier, separate space, independent, extraordinary, or sacred. It can be crossed through make-believe, to make one's fictional presence possible in the fictional world. Although a game's border between reality and fiction shares similar characteristics with the sacred's, Caillois establishes a list of differences between game and the sacred, play and prayer. The dichotomy between ordinary and extraordinary life, from a sociological perspective, was defined by Durkheim ([1912] 2005) with his distinction between the profane, what belongs to ordinary life, and the sacred, what is apart from everyday life. Later, Huizinga ([1938] 1998) notes that play is about "stepping out of 'real' life into a temporary sphere of activity with a disposition all of its own" (8). This sphere is one of the "festival and ritual—the sacred sphere" (ibid.), or in other words, islands of time.

This assimilation of play to the sacred will be very quickly criticised by Caillois ([1939] 1988) by making multiple distinctions. First, games are pure form, for the rules are respected only because they are rules, while the sacred is pure content, an overwhelming force that people attempt to capture through rituals (134). In Pavel's terms, games have a very intelligible *Magnum Opus* while the sacred cannot. People can submit to the sacred, with prayer as the fundamental attitude, and they can be creators of games, like the "magician who constrains the forces he employs" (ibid.). Second, games and the sacred have an inverse relationship to everyday life, the former being relaxation from life, without as many responsibilities, consequences and contingencies (175), while the latter exists to influence and improve everyday life (176). "In summary, one feels as much relieved when one goes from the sacred activity to profane life as when one goes from its preoccupations and vicissitudes to the game climate" (177, my translation).

Caillois develops his analysis of games as social practices in *Les jeux et les hommes* (1958). Although many social activities present aspects of the nature of play, what makes games extraordinary is that they are "cultural forms staying at the margin of the social mechanism" (92;

my translation), to which sports (game of competitions), casinos (game of chance), the carnival (game of simulacrum), or alpinism (game of vertigo) belong (ibid.). They are distinct from their institutionalised forms integrated into social life such as commercial competition, stock market speculation, uniforms, or professional acrobats, and their corrupted forms such as violence, superstition, alienation, and drugs (ibid.). Caillois does not explicitly refer to the imaginary but his definition of the relationship between games and the world, is in line with Bachelard's ([1957] 1961) concept of 'miniature', a focus of the perception on a small part of the world, in a manner of a magnifying glass, which constitutes an imaginary world of its own:

I'm more at home in miniature worlds. For me, these are dominated worlds. [...] The miniature, sincerely lived, detaches me from the surrounding world, helps me to resist the dissolution of the atmosphere. The miniature is an exercise in metaphysical freshness; it makes it possible to worldify⁹ at small risk. And what a restful exercise in a dominated world! The miniature rests without ever putting you to sleep. The imagination is vigilant and happy. (Bachelard [1957] 1961, 150-151; my translation)

This image of the game space is separated through focus, putting reality on the margins of the game's world, and the miniature as a potential world, basis for a universe. Games are worlds based on a small part of the world that is 'worldified'. The shift of focus is not a delimitation of space, it is a shift of the anchoring of reality itself, for what is counted as actual and fictional, or possible. It is a two-way movement, a breath, between the entire world, which is given a new meaning through the miniature but also giving the miniature its meaning, for it is part of the world. In the same way that everyday life's world puts play on the margins of society, play as miniaturisation puts everyday life on the margins. The border between reality and fiction is here the miniaturisation's threshold under which imagination allows one to perceive beyond the sensible. *The play space is thus separated from everyday life through a focus of attention high enough that it makes imagination necessary for the play space's existence.* The question of where to put this threshold, this 'high enough', leads me to the study of distance between reality and fiction.

⁹ The original term is the neologism *mondifier*, "to transform into a world". The english edition (2009) translated it as "to be world conscious" (161) which does not encapture the transformation operated.

5.4. Make-believe

5.4.1. Make-believe as expression: repetition and creation

Following Walton's (1984; 1980; 1993) theories on fiction and make-believe, one experiences a world of fiction through make-believe of different sorts. As a form of expression, in a Merleau-Pontian sense (Landes 2013), make-believe is at the same time repetition and creation. The players play in a space with a set of truths that differs from the actual world, in which they can express themselves through the actualisation and expansion of this set of truths. Evans (1982) states three different kinds of principles that govern make-believe games: the first are the *basic principles*, in the same manner as Pavel's First Book, they establish the fundamental set of truth valuable for the game; the second are the *incorporation principles*, truth from the actual worlds, compatible with the basic principles, that players can actualise as truth for the make-believe game; the third is the *recursive principle* making the logical development of new sets of truths possible (354).

Evans defines two different kinds of make-believe games that characterise this opposition between repetition and creation. The *existentially conservative* game is one where for everything of the fictional world there is a corresponding actual world counterpart (358), whereas an *existentially creative* game is when "the pretence is not that something which there is other than it is, but that there is something which in fact there isn't" (ibid.). To understand make-believe games as forms of expression, it is necessary to consider the conservative and creative categories as a spectrum where games are both at the same time. I propose to reuse the mythologist term of *deformation*, where the minimum deformation is 'reproduction' and the maximum deformation is 'creation'.

The aspects of make-believe games that are reproduction of the actual world fall under the category of simulation. Taking the example of Evans's make-believe game where children play to bake a pie and the pie is a shaped bit of mud and the oven a metallic object, one can easily observe the semantic deformation where the usual sign 'pie' is deformed by replacing its signifier by a piece of mud. This game is existentially conservative, its function is to take the activity of baking a pie to put it into an imaginary bubble, a game, where the reality of the game is limited to this activity. The creativity of the game is minimal but resides in the semantic

deformation. In the other example of shadowboxing, the creativity of the game is maximal because no sign is deformed and the imaginary boxer is a pure product of imagination.

5.4.2. Expanding make-believe deformation/distance to a structural understanding through unnatural narratives

Unnatural narrative theories give me the tools to expand the analysis of deformation from a semantic level into structural levels. There is a spectrum of fictional worlds that span from conservative to creative and can be examined through unnatural narrative theories as they “seek to describe the ways in which projected story worlds deviate from real-world frames” (Alber et al. 2010, 116):

The term unnatural denotes physically impossible scenarios and events, that is, impossible by the known laws governing the physical world, as well as logically impossible ones, that is, impossible by accepted principles of logic. (Alber 2009, 80)

Fludernik (1996) situates the origin of natural narrative in oral everyday discourse, the narrative that is the closest to our everyday experience. The further something is from our everyday experience, the more unnatural it is. The threshold between reality and fiction is here more deformation- or rather distance-centred; it is not the capacity to create a fictional world, to worldify from a miniature, rather it is the difficulty to enter such a world. The fictional world and players are distanced because, on one hand, the fictional world is unnatural and, on the other hand, players make efforts to inhabit such a world, to make sense of the new set of truths they cannot always translate into real-world terms. The players’ process of understanding the fictional world is called narrativisation (Fludernik 1996) or naturalisation (Wolf 2013).

Multiple parameters are to be taken into account to evaluate the distance between actual players and fictional worlds. It is first possible to quantify the degree of irrealism of the fiction: this can be done through an account of the counterfactual utterances necessary to describe the fictional world with its actual world counterparts—and whether it is possible or not. These counterfactual utterances can be sorted depending on the actual world laws they break, focusing on the kind of truth they fictionalise, whether it is semantic (deformation of a sign, establishing the basic

principles), physical (deformation of an objective system, the base principles influence the incorporation principle), logical (deformation of the recursive principle), or ontological (deformation of the border between worlds).

Using Evan's terminology, semantic fictionalisation focuses on the basic principles of a make-believe game but only deforms the meaning of a sign. Physical fictionalisation deforms the incorporation principles, meaning that the fictional world is given a system ruling the interactions between its incorporated objects different from the actual world's. The fictionalisation of logic deforms the recursive principles, meaning that the system allowing the establishment of new truths from already fictional objects is different from the actual world's. There are three categories of things that are possibly deformed through fiction. The first has already been covered and concerns semantic deformation, a mythification, and the creation of a new sign. The second concerns the deformation of scientific systems from the actual world, meaning that actual scientific laws are broken in the fictional world. The third concerns the deformation of logic, the metasystem ruling how scientific systems can be established. This does not mean that fictional scientific laws cannot be established, but they have to be within the logic of the fictional world. Finally, the fictional world can be more or less ontologically separated from or linked to its reference world. This latter point is explored through the concept of metalepsis.

If theories of make-believe focus on the experiencer side of the experience of fiction, metalepsis theories focus on the world side. They analyse how characters, the fictional subjects of experience, relate to players, the actual subjects of experience. This parallel has been drawn by Pavel as follows:

Caught up in the story, Walton's spectator projects a fictional ego that takes part in the imaginary happenings; symmetrically, Ryan's author impersonates a fictional speaker or writer who fully belongs to the imaginary world and in this capacity introduces the fictional beings and states of affairs to the fictional ego of the reader. (Pavel 1986, 88)

If people's lives are in between fiction and reality, in between figural and literal, I read them as parables, and they are their characters. If their lives are complete fiction, what results is that they are a continuous performance, a constant game of make-believe, they live in a simulation. If their

lives are pure reality, they are in the simple structure of Empire, for reality is lived through subjectivity.

5.5. *Mythic origin of players vs Empire*

There is a very real sphere that is far less accessible than play or the sacred: the Moon. Except for a few astronauts, the Moon is an inaccessible place, a place to which travel seems possible, and, like Earth, a place that links all humanity together.

Antiquity starts the tradition that the Moon is an incorporeal place albeit hovering tantalizingly close to our earthy world. ... In the Greek mind, the distance between the Earth and the Moon, however formidable, could be breached. Usually this was accomplished by souls and daemones who crossed the boundary with regularity. (Ní Mheallaigh 2020, 111)

The earliest fictional trip to the moon, *The Incredible Things Beyond Thule* (late first/early second century CE), was already given in the form of a hoax, making it possible to connect antiquity to the Great Hoax of 1835 through “scientific fiction” (Ní Mheallaigh 2020, 214). Ní Mheallaigh finds in ancient Greek fiction about the Moon both a “philosophical detachment from our world” (290) and “older traditions of ... thought that had insistently entangled the Moon with life on Earth over the centuries” (ibid.). Space conquest did not change this ambivalent relationship: “[i]f the Moon was at last a destination and an extension of our world, it was equally a point of distance, separation and alienation: to go there means always to look back”(ibid.). The Moon belongs to the same space as the mythical, the imaginal, or the daydream, it “is not a place of this world (which correlates to the realm of *historia*, narratives of fact), nor yet is it an entirely imaginary place like other spaces in True Stories” (236).

Different fictional travels to the Moon echo the travels to the fictional space, especially to the sphere of games. The moon travellers of *Kepler's Dream* (Lear 2020)¹⁰ need extensive knowledge, books, and magic to be able to travel (Schenkel 2022, 295). The Moon, in the earliest science fiction novels, like Bergerac's *Voyage dans la Lune* ([1657] 1898), is a place for subversion and critique of the existing power. Jules Verne's *De la Terre à la Lune* ([1886] 1966)

¹⁰ Johannes Kepler's *Somnium* was originally published in 1634 in Latin and was republished in english in Lears' *Kepler's Dream*.

showcases two possible worlds on the Moon—as in Burroughs’s space (1986)—: either the American civilizing conquest or the travel to the absurd embodied by the Frenchman (Schenkel 2022, 301). I argue that the distance necessary to travel to a game is the same as the one to the Moon. It is either the minimal distance, the equation of reality with fiction, the American conquest of fiction, or the maximal distance, the absurd travel to space:

The distance from the game allowing the contingency is also the player’s herself with what she does. ... It is a *distanciation* doubled by a derealisation: the player who knows that she plays loses contact with reality. There is an illusion of ‘game’, meaning there is an entry into the game. (Bonenfant 2013, 3; my translation and emphasis)

5.5.1. Myths: of Power and Knowledge

In a myth-ritual theory approach to Carse’s (1986) finite and infinite players, it is possible to identify two sorts and attitudes toward the myth. Let me first provide a short definition of a myth useful for this section: “A myth is a sacred narrative explaining how the world and man came to be in their present form” (Dundes 1984, 1). If the finite player plays to win (Carse 1986, 11), that means their goal is to finish the myth, i.e., to attain a state of stability. For that a double categorisation of myths is required. The first is the distinction between two *functions* for spreading a myth: the first is the legitimisation of a king’s authority, particularly through succession myth, and the second the construction of a scribe’s knowledge, aiming to explain the origin of the world (Myerston 2022, 5; 8). As such the king and the scribe are postures, ideologies, attitudes, that can give the same myth two different meanings and functions (8):

royal and scribal ideologies operated independently as two autonomous systems: while the royal discourse aimed at legitimizing power, the inner discourse of the scribes worked towards producing knowledge about the world. (Myerston 2022, 8)

Used as a conclusion in Myerston’s article, myth is described by two functions by Lincoln (2014, 3): reproducing established social forms, the definition of an institution or power structure, and the “construction, deconstruction and reconstruction of society itself” (Lincoln 2014, 3). The stable Empire is opposed to the unstable player:

Every mythology presents a successive and coherent series of primordial events, but different peoples judge these fabulous acts in different ways, *underlining the importance of some of them, casting aside, or even completely neglecting, others.* (Eliade 1967, 178; my emphasis)

The second categorisation of cosmogonic myths, established by Eliade (1967) is defined by the focus on the origin, the type of primordiality one constructs a sacred history from, associated with two kinds of religious nostalgia. The cosmogonic myth has a definite function as “an exemplary model” that is “periodically reactualised” (182), but the sacred histories made from that myth differ in function. The pre-cosmic primordiality focuses on the unity of the world before the cosmogony, i.e., the breaking up of the world, implying a longing for the original unity and the ritualisation of this movement, from unity to fragmented reality. This is an unhistorical primordiality. The cosmogonic primordiality focuses on the start of the sacred history, what happens right after the cosmogony, and implies

the longing to recover the primordial epoch that began immediately after the creation (the Aranda type). In this latter case the nostalgia yearns for the *sacred history* of the tribe. (Eliade 1967, 183)

It is possible to establish a double pairing of the king’s attitude with the cosmogonic primordiality and the scribe’s attitude with the pre-cosmic primordiality: the king needs to select the primordial events that legitimise his authority, and the scribe needs to be as complete as possible about the origin of the world without hierarchising between primordial events. The king cannot construct a sacred history without hierarchising mythological events, and the scribe cannot explain the origin of all things if some of them are neglected.

However, one last element is necessary to be able to adapt these theories to games and players.

5.5.2. *Players and Empire’s temporalities*

5.5.2.1. Death: cycle or eschatology

The theories mentioned so far show an understanding of myth as being reactualised, exemplary, and cyclical, with a passage from one state to another. However, human life is not eternal, there is a linear beginning and end, a birth and a death. Two notions are here to be compared, the

different models of myths about death and the historicity of an authoritarian regime, through their relation with time and eternity.

Beliefs about the unknown fate of the dead illustrate *the function of myth, translating the real and punctual into terms of the ideal and durative, projecting ritual procedure to the plane of the ideal situation*. (Fiske 1969, 249; my emphasis)

Fiske (1969) enumerates a list of attributes of myths about death. Death is "insatiable hunger" (254), "darkness" and "silence" (259), "homeless wandering" (260), "transformation" (261), "the loss of distinction and rank" (262), and the "abode of the dead is hidden" (258). Death is part of the cycle of "suffering, death and resurrection and rebirth" (265). This cycle is closely related to seasonal rites and myths of vegetation gods.

Against this cyclical practice of myth, this cyclical historicity, it is possible to oppose the stasis urged by fascist regimes as analysed by Chapoutot (2012) in his study of nazi historicity. Nazi rhetoric is based on a double eschatology; they can either win or lose history by purifying the Aryan race or by losing it in the mix of races. It is a double narrative based on biology and history anchored in an eternal myth outside of cyclical and deferential conceptions of time. In other words, it is outside of time. Eternity, the compression of history and the resulting stasis are associated with a rhetoric of emergency, pushing the regime to go to war before it is too late to save the race. Chapoutot notes the flooding use of superlatives in Nazi rhetoric, letting no space for alternatives breath or imagination (51). The Nazi ideology is alimented by the hate of the Jew, whom they historically make the exact equal of the Christian under the Roman empire, or the Bolsheviks, i.e. they are not comparing mechanism of power but establishing a complete identity between these figures:

Time is not therefore an axis on which differences succeed one another, it is not even a cycle: time is a stasis, frozen in an eternal present where everything is equivalent, where the Jew of yesterday, the one who fought Rome in Carthage or Palestine, is the Soviet Jew, where Hannibal is Stalin, where Hitler is Fabius Cunctator and Frederick II. (Chapoutot 2012, 51; my translation)

To be able to dive deeper into an understanding of cyclical and eschatological historicities, and how they relate to the players-Empire dichotomy, it is necessary to define time and to see how the *practice* of time differs for players and Empire.

5.5.2.2. Merleau-Ponty's definition of time

[E]xistence cannot have external or contingent attributes. It cannot be whatever—spatial, sexual, temporal—without being a whole, without taking back and handling its 'attributes' and making dimensions of its being out of them, in sort that a slightly precise analysis of each of them concerns, in reality, the subjectivity itself. There are no dominant problems and subordinated problems: all problems are concentric. (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 469)

Merleau-Ponty conceives time as “the power of out-running and of ‘nihilating’ (*néantiser*) which dwells within us and is ourselves” (2002, 497). In this context, time can only be conceived outside of its flow. The given example is the one of the flowing river, in which the conception of past and future depends on where the observer is placed (471). If one observes the mouth of the river, the already flowed waters lay in the past while the source represents the future water; the time roles of the source and mouth of the river are reversed if the observer is at the source. If the observer flows with the river the landscapes outside of the river constitute the past and future of the observer. This example aims to illustrate that the common conception of time as flowing implies an observer, a subjectivity situated outside the flow of time.

Merleau-Ponty further argues that as much as time cannot exist without a subject, the subject cannot exist without time, in the sense that one “should understand time as subject and the subject as time” (483). On this basis, the possibility for subjects to be conscious of non-existence stems from the conception of time, with a past that does not exist anymore, a future that does not exist yet, and a present that is “the zone where the being and the consciousness coincide” (485). Developing on this last formula, the past is where the being and consciousness have coincided, and the future is where they will coincide.

Time thus can be understood in two ways: ‘historical’ time, the outside perspective that conceives a meaningful flowing succession of events, and ‘natural time’ a meaningless,

ever-actualising present. The former presupposes a transcendental self and the latter an empirical self. Consequently, subjectivity needs to be distinguished both from the transcendental ipseity of the self, the Heideggerian historical time, and from the empirical self with a succession of identities, the Husserlian *Abschattungen*. The former corresponds to Ricoeur's (1990) identity in the sense of "ipseity" (12) and the latter to identity in the sense of "idem" (11-12). Rather, subjectivity is defined by its capacity to "open itself to an Other and to go out of itself" (487). Reversing Sartre's conception of identity through time (Sartre 1943, 183), time and subjectivity are an acquired spontaneity that perpetuates itself to the being, because it is acquired (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 488-89). It is the subjective experience of time that produces the two types of identity defined by Ricoeur (1990) as the 'ipseity identity' whose function is to distinguish one from the other, and the 'idem identity' whose function is to equate one with the other.

5.5.2.3. Players and Time

Time as the opening of the Self to the Other can be studied in a player-avatar perspective, for which Eliade's (1949) two figures opposed by their conception of time allow to refine players' phenomenology as double situated. The first is mythical, based on repetition and associated with the avatar's perception, and the other is historical, based on irreversibility¹¹ and associated with the player. The mythical is based on the reproduction of the "archetypal model" (Eliade 1949, 19), which excludes from memory any event outside of it (ibid., 127). As such, the time loop in which the avatar is trapped when dying and reviving devalues the player's time and preserves the continuity of the game's narrative branch. While the avatar "through this repetition lives ceaselessly in the present" (ibid., 129), the player has "the power of out-running and of 'nihilating' ('néantiser') which dwells within us and is ourselves" (Merleau-Ponty 2006, 497). Only certain events are retained as the 'history' of the game, they are what players remember as irreversible. During the game, the avatar's death is only temporary because it is irrelevant to the game's myth. It becomes only relevant when it coincides with the end of the game, the eschatological myth's culmination.

¹¹ Eliade uses the outdated terms 'archaic man' and 'modern man' which are here replaced by 'mythical' and 'historical'.

In Turner's (1974) terms, every challenge of the game can be analysed as a miniature *rite de passage* where failure is on the margin of the myth and success is the threshold toward a new part of the world. The repetition of failure, the avatar's death and resurrection loop, is liminal, it transforms the avatar, but it is liminoid, i.e., a marginal transformation, for the player who only temporarily abandons her temporality to flow through the game. The game itself is a *rite de passage* and constitutes a liminal space for the player because it enriches her with a new experience of the Other. Merleau-Ponty expresses this kind of transformation in a poetic style: "all those we have loved, detested, known, or simply glimpsed speak through our voice" (Merleau-Ponty 1964, 19).

5.5.2.3.1. Juul's play and fictional time

The process of getting back and forth in and outside of the flow of time has been widely explored in game studies. In *Half-Real* (2005), Juul proposes a categorisation of time between *play time* and *fictional time*. The former is in abstract games, for instance, *Tetris* (Pajitnov 1985), checkers or soccer, and is defined by the experience of the present, in short: "[e]verything in the game happens *now*" (Juul 2005, 142; original emphasis). *Fictional time* is the time of events in the game's world (143). The easiest case of dissociation between play and fictional time happens during cut-scenes (147), moments when the game temporarily transforms into a movie making the player unable to interact. It can be a simple ratio change between actual world, and the game world time, for example, football video games usually have a ratio of 1:6 between play and fictional time, so a 90-minute football match in the game world happens in 15 minutes in the actual world.

The situation is more complex to analyse when it comes to flashbacks and flashforwards, depending on their degree of interactivity. A non-interactive flashback is similar to a recollection of memory, "an interactive flashback leads to the time machine problem: the player's actions in the past may suddenly render the present impossible" (148). For flashforwards, if they are cut-scenes, this is reminiscent of the Heideggerian historical time stemming from the future (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 489) thus limiting agency to the present experience. If the flashforward is playable, it would be more appropriate to name it another game level, and in this case, both playtime and fictional time are undefined (150). Because Juul posits that "[g]ames are supposed

to be enjoyable experiences” (2005, 155), the use of his theories about the experience of time is limited to the specific context of fun, outside of this thesis’s scope. He later undermines this presupposition in *The Art of Failure* (2013), through the observation that failure, as a non-enjoyable experience, is still constitutive of the game experience.

5.5.2.3.2. Ryan’s terminology of suspense and temporal immersion

Ryan’s (2001) terminology of suspense allows for a deeper analysis of the experience of time. In her definition, human time,

by contrast [to clock time], is a quasi-musical experience in which the present is not a moving point but a moving window that encompasses memories of the past and premonitions of the future. (Ryan 2001, 141)

This definition is compatible with Merleau-Ponty’s, where the window is an anticipation of the future and the development of the past, the “horizons of originary past and future” (1945, 485). Furthermore, the example of music to describe the unity of experience is also used by Merleau-Ponty (1945, 213) and is widespread among theorists of phenomenology (cf. DUBY 2019).

Ryan defines suspense as the reason for temporal immersion, “the reader’s desire for the knowledge that awaits her at the end of narrative time” (2001, 140). The end of narrative time differs from the end of a linear storyline, in the sense that it includes nonlinear, broken, unnatural storytelling, which, as Juul observed, is most prominent in video games. Temporal immersion indeed goes beyond the first reading of a text or the knowledge of ‘the end’, or otherwise tragedy, indeed any narrative with a destiny to accomplish, would not be very successful genres. In this context, Ryan establishes four types of suspense. The *what suspense* focuses on “the imminent resolution of binary alternative: will good or bad happen to the heroine?” (143). It is the most common understanding of suspense in a linear story. The *how suspense* focuses not on “the future but the prehistory of a certain state” (ibid.), where the “outcome is given in advance” (ibid.) with flashforwards, or because of the audience’s knowledge. The *who suspense*, exemplified by the whodunit, has the specificity of including two temporal planes, the murder

and the investigation (ibid.). Lastly, the *meta suspense* focuses on “how the author is going to tie all the strands together and give the text proper narrative form”(ibid.). It implies a critical involvement with the story, making the dynamics of storytelling more immersing than the “ticking away of story-time” (ibid.):

Generally speaking, temporal immersion is *the reader's involvement* in the process by which the progression of narrative time distills the field of the potential, selecting one branch as the actual, *confining the others to the realm of the forever virtual*, or counterfactual, and as a result of this selection continually generates new ranges of virtualities. The passing of time matters to the reader because *it is not a mere accumulation of time particles but a process of disclosure*. (Ryan 2001, 141; my emphasis)

This definition sheds new light on the power of ‘nihilating’ attributed to time: it is the voluntary capacity to tell what is and what is not. Suspense is an understanding of time not as a thing the audience is submitted to, but as an active and voluntary phenomenon through which one can make sense of one’s subjectivity. It is not entirely located in the transcendental ‘I’, because it only exists during one’s experience of a narrative, nor in the empirical ‘I’ who is only an object of time.

5.5.2.4. Empire’s Time: universal collective memory

Halbwachs (1925) coined the term *mémoire collective*, “collective memory”, a milestone for developing an awareness of Empire. Before Halbwachs, the concept already existed in ‘posterity’, which was then, in the Western tradition, defined by its transcendence from the human condition, giving immortality to those who are remembered. It is distanced “from the contingency of human temporality” (Russell 2006, 796). The people who are part of collective memory were both heroes, “exemplary figures from the past [who] should *serve as models for ethical behavior*” (793; my emphasis) and artists, remembered both for their ethical and aesthetic glory (ibid.). The thinkers of the time considered these models to be universal, without considering the groups that they were part of (794). Representatives of the dominant imperial ideology of the time, examples of heroic figures are glorified Roman gods of war, as found in

Ronsard's poetry (*ibid.*). The remembered poets are both examples and motivation to inscribe oneself in posterity (795). These pre-Halbwachsian conceptions of collective memory are proper to Empire, as they are aimed to be universal, without borders, normative and to live through infinite linear time, beyond the limits of death. By analysing "who remembers and how that happens" (Russel 2006, 796), Halbwachs's theories brought a delimitation in space and time of collective memories that are both formed by and define social groups.

Empire builds its identity through atemporal beings, heroes and artists of the past, sites of memory and eschatological myths. This conception of time does not take into account the finitude of existence, quite on the opposite, it aims for immortality, breaking free of the human contingencies as found in the Nazi ontology.

Nazi ontology is simple, because binary, and effective: Nazism takes into account the flight of the gods and the finitude of the individual. This finitude, this irremediable individual mortality, is countered by the immortality of an infinite race as long as its perpetuation is ensured. (Chapoutot 2012, 53; my translation)

The primacy of the transcendental self in Empire is explicitly rejected by Merleau-Ponty, as he argues that "one should not deal with the transcendental 'I' as the true subject, and the empirical me as its shadow or its wake" (1945, 487-488). In this sense, the absence of territorial and temporal boundaries under Empire (Hardt and Negri 2000, xiv-xv) is incompatible with Merleau-Ponty's conception of time, for "a time that would not have its root in a present and therefore in a past would not be time but eternity" (Merleau-Ponty 1945, 489).

By definition, games are limited in time, making them closer to the real experience of time. By going back to the experience of time itself, it is possible to realise that time is inherent to one's subjectivity and that one can consider oneself an object of time only by othering oneself through reflection. This reflection is the nihilating power of subjectivity, the capacity to understand the past and the future as meaningful through their virtualisation. This implies that the virtual future self is meaningful only because of the existence of the subjective present self. This leads to a total rethinking of posterity as meaningless because of its complete dissociation between existence and time. Therefore Empire's atemporality causes a crisis of meaning in people's experience of time.

This crisis of meaning can be solved through games as a practice of phenomenology, making possible the experience of eternity. All games end with the fictional failure of their participants. Once the game is over, the game world disappears, and its characters cease to exist, only their virtuality remains in the actual world. Players thus enter the game's world with the knowledge of their inevitable fictional death. What happens after the end of the game, after death, is a future where being and consciousness never coincide, a place outside of the experience of time, a non-time, i.e., eternity. In this perspective, players make their experience of time meaningful both through the *what suspense*, situated at the end of the game, the liminal place after the game and before the game's death, and the *how suspense* during the whole game. The experience of eternity is thus made possible because the actual player existed before and will exist after the game. In other words, players are not objects of Empire's atemporality, but subjects of eternity, creating their atemporality.

Game studies theories about functions or rhetorics of play (Sutton-Smith [1997] 2010) link myth and games, meaning that they abstract games from myth. They tend to reproduce, deform, or create only to retain their overarching function rather than their narrative.

6. How to find player figures? The affective complexity of games, marginals and postmodern confusion.

6.1. Players are where the liminal affects are: nostalgia, magical realism, and the uncanny

The way to intuitively find players opposed to Empire, meaning without theoretical analysis, is to follow liminal affects like nostalgia, magical realism, or the uncanny. Confusion might be one of the strongest markers of the postmodern era. Some argue that people live in the nostalgia era (Bauman 2017), the longing for the past, the U-turn from Utopia, what enables the confusion between the lost in time and the present, history and memory, desire and achieving desire. Nostalgia is a longing, not the achievement of what one is longing for. It is a bittersweet feeling, not entirely joyful nor sad, as complex as the uncanny, a horrifying fascination, the impossibility

to deciding what category something belongs to. Magical realism works by including magic in a real-life simulation, and considers it normal, a subversion of everyday life hierarchies (Zamora and Faris 1995).

These affects produce marginalised figures: the poet and the philosopher (Boym 2001, xvii), the freak (Fiedler 1978), and the child (Sutton-Smith [1995] 2012). The first lives through their emotion without hierarchising them. The freak is not human enough, it is abnormal, and very special (Fiedler 1978). The child is also among the marginalised figures and through make-believe, they bring their fictional world to reality (Sutton-Smith [1997] 2010; [1995] 2012). The affective focus that has allowed me to select the different theories is the one of nostalgia, the uncanny, and magical realism, liminal affects that put one into ontologically paradoxical affective states. The experience of play is correlated with these liminal affects, due to the double situatedness (cf. Ensslin 2011) of players, both inside and outside the game. They are affects where one's imagination is the determining factor regarding the existence of the objects of nostalgia, the uncanny or magical realism. Nostalgia would be memory if it was not enriched with imaginary perception, making one perceive that something no longer exists. The uncanny relies on uncertainty, the impossibility to attribute a definite meaning to what one perceives. Make-believe is the possibility to both know and ignore that one is playing. It is the necessary distance, in the sense of Henriot (1978), for one to perceive things as real while knowing they are fictional.

6.2. The actual players are Marginals

The actual players my thesis is about are not a creation of mine, but a product of normalising power. The study of power structures, of the mechanisms that create the normal and abnormal categories of existence needs to be conducted to find players, the people forced to make their bubble of meaningful existence as something else than abnormal. On one hand, players are victims of oppression, “the exploitative exercise of power by individuals and groups over others” (Clifford and Burke 2009, 16). On the other hand, they can act as anti-oppressors, arguing “for multiplicity of voices, opinions and ways of thinking and being of marginalized groups in order to counter the arrow dichotomies” (Gunraj and Ruiz 2011, 257).

I consider participants of subcultures as players, people who can subvert the functions of the means given by the hegemonic political system. The games they play are repressed by authoritarian regimes, transforming games into political struggle. There is an ambiguity between playing, creating an extraordinary space, considered as such by its participants, that one can voluntarily enter or exit, and the meaning it takes on as a subspace, resistance to a global political system. The pervasion of everyday life by institutions leads to the pervasion of these institutions on the borders of subcultures. I want to highlight the fact that institutions can only attack the borders of a game. From an outsider's perspective, the signs used in a game are understood with their everyday life meaning, or not understood if they are creative in-game expressions, i.e., if they do not have a real-world counterpart. In that regard, institutions can only perceive the external appearance of a game, reading it like a foreign language. Institutional mechanisms of universalisation of institutions will result either in *assimilation*, meaning the attribution of an institutional meaning to the game, or *annihilation*, the destruction of the game through repression. Often the former leads to the second.

6.3. *The Eradication of Nostalgia*

There is no other homage than remembrance, no other real cult than critical memory; no other love than complicity in their obsessions. Everything is dream, almost everything turns into nightmare. (Taibo II [1998] 2011, 9)

6.3.1. *Genealogy 1: Medical Definition*

Tracing the genealogy of nostalgia from the medical creation of the term, to its eradication and transformation into an aesthetic, illustrates well the institutional mechanisms of assimilation and annihilation. The word ‘nostalgia’ was coined by Hoffer in 1688 in his thesis *Dissertatio medica de Nostalgia oder Heimweh* (Kiser Anspach 1934; Boym 2001, 3; Sprengler 2009, 11; Ferraty 2018, 39) and came to replace the German term *Heimweh*, “the homesickness” (Ferraty 2018, 39). The affect of longing for something that is not here anymore and that has been described by poets for centuries was assimilated by the medical institution. An interesting application of this medical knowledge is to be found in military context, described by Zwinger in an added chapter

to the republication of Hoffer's thesis in 1710 (Fuentenebro and Valiente Ots 2014, 405), where a song, the *Ranz des vaches*, had to be banned because it would trigger dangerous symptoms of nostalgia in soldiers. Towards the end of the 18th century, 'nostalgia' became an indicator for military hygiene, as a report on a French army created from a 1793-94 program of mass conscription estimates "that up to 5 percent of soldiers suffered the disease" (O'Sullivan 2012, 627-8). Thus identified as a 'disease', nostalgia becomes an enemy that has to be eradicated for the good of imperial conquest. The treatment of nostalgia during the first half of the 19th century intersects with Foucault's work on psychiatric institutions in the figure of Philippe Pinel, the founder of the hospital as a place of moral uniformisation (Foucault 1972, 513):

The doctor could only enforce his absolute authority on the asylum in a way, that from the start, he has been Father and Judge, Family and Law, his medical practice would not for a long time comment the old rites of Order, Authority and Punishment. And Pinel recognises well that the doctor heals when, outside of modern therapeutics, he puts in play these immemorial figures. (Foucault 1972, 521; my translation)

As such, the 19th century is a turning point for nostalgia, which is not only analysed and treated in the field, but considered a biologically universal disease found among "animals to the savage man, and from the savage man to the civilised man" (Pinel and Boisseau 1821, 661). The overrepresentation of Bretons in the 1794 pandemic made the cure of nostalgia an essential element of the integrative power of French imperialism, especially through the 'moral' cure deployed by the Ideologues, Pinel amongst them (O'Sullivan 2012), whose intention is to reinforce French institutions to create an improvement (*perfectionnement*) of the masses through education and the control of habits and behaviour (Th¹² 1801, 522-3; 525). This grotesque medicalisation of nostalgia reaches its peak in the 1865's *Dictionary of Medicine* where it is claimed that "the cerebral meninges are found to be thickened or at least congested, as is the digestive mucosa" (Nysten and Littré 1865, 1014; my translation) in the autopsy of a patient 'ill' from nostalgia.

¹² The article is signed 'F. Th'. It is most probable that because of the risk of censorship first under Robespierre and then under Napoléon, most of the contributors of the *Décade philosophique, littéraire et politique* stayed anonymous.

Throughout the 20th century, nostalgia slowly loses military use. Journals such as the *New York Times*, for instance, would declare people dying from nostalgia until the late 1930s, and it was still part of military worries until the end of World War 2, before giving place to its political use (Sprengler 2009). It is possible to recognise a shift in the military medicalisation of nostalgia from being away from home to war trauma and the difficulty of being home again (Cabanis 2006), from curing nostalgia to curing post-traumatic stress disorder. This medical history of nostalgia epitomizes the movement of assimilation, the reappropriation of a complex affect of longing for home by institutions and its generalisation to every beings, and its annihilation through different ways of curing nostalgia.

Its political use is ‘restorative nostalgia’, a term coined by Boym (2001) to define the impossible promise of reproducing the past in conservative political discourse. It is an assimilation of the poetic longing for something that is no more, as found in Homer’s *Odyssey* (Boym 2001, 7), in pre-islamic poetry as *Nasīb* (cf. Khankan 2002), in Chinese Tang and Song poetry as *Haigu* (cf. Xiang 2015) and later defended as *nostalgia* by Rousseau in 1768, by the political institutions. Although the histories of the two understandings of nostalgia intersect, the poetic one has a different genealogy which is explored by Bauman in *Retrotopia* (2017) that presents the same power mechanisms as the medical one.

6.3.2. Genealogy 2: Poetic Definition

The other genealogy follows the evolution of Utopia throughout modes of governmentality from the 18th century to neoliberalism. In *Retrotopia* (2017), Bauman examines the shift of society from looking forward to a better future, to looking backwards into a better past, in a similar manner to Benjamin’s ‘Angel of History’ ([1940] 1986, 257), an interpretation of Klee’s *Angelus Novus* (1920). Bauman’s observation of the historical evolution of political regimes matches Foucault’s observation of the history of government regimes (2004), the former analysing the consequences on people’s imagination, and the latter the birth of biopolitics. Retrotopias are the “Hegelian triad formed by a double negation” (Bauman 2017, 4) of Thomas More’s *Utopia* ([1516] 1965) described as follows:

After the prospects of human happiness – tied since More to a *topos* (a fixed place, a polis, a city, a sovereign state – each under a wise and benevolent ruler) – have been unfixed, untied from any particular *topos* and individualized, privatized and personalized (‘subsidiarized’ to human individuals after the pattern of snails’ homes), it is their turn now to be negated by what they valiantly and all but successfully attempted to negate. (Bauman 2017, 4; original emphasis)

Bauman’s *topos* is found in Foucault’s description of the traditional ‘*raison d’État*’, the definition and limitation of the state’s power, sustained by the “prince’s wisdom” (Foucault 2004, 19) with a maximisation of the state’s governmental practices, succeeded by the “*gouvernement frugal*”, a minimisation of the governmental practices (30). The progressive decline of governmental actions gives space for the apparition of the *homo æconomicus* which is “not the man of the exchange, not the consumer man, but the man of the company [*entreprise*] and of the production” (154; my translation). This society, sustained by laws which let “individuals the possibility of behaving as they want in the form of the free company” (180; my translation), is the reason for the first negation of More’s *Utopia*, namely, neoliberalism. Without directly naming it, Bauman describes some of its characteristics:

Privatization/individualization of the idea of ‘progress’ and of the pursuit of life’s improvements were sold by the powers that be and embraced by most of their subjects as liberation: breaking free from the stern demands of subordination and discipline – at the cost of social services and state protection. (Bauman 2017, 5)

In Bauman’s understanding, the leading fear of this system is the “horror of inadequacy” (5), sustained by normative politics. The second negation, the ‘U-turn’, is due to the after-effects of neoliberalism, the fear of a future that is ever-decaying. Bauman’s ‘Age of Nostalgia’ is arguably the predominance of ‘the present of the past’ in people’s imaginary and its expression can be observed through reproductions of and reflections about the past (cf. Boym 2001) possibly leading to either conservative or creative nostalgia. The next section explores the diversity of nostalgic expressions through the lens of video game nostalgia.

6.4.3. Video Game Nostalgia

An article in *The Guardian* titled “Why Are Younger Generations Embracing the Retro Game Revival?”, dating from April 2024, describes the increasing success of retro-gaming:

On TikTok, #retrogaming videos have amassed over 6bn views. On YouTube, uploads have increased 1,000-fold. Spotify users are creating 50% more retro-gaming-themed playlists than they were at this time last year, and live streamers are cashing in on the repetitive catchphrases and mechanical movements of NPCs (non-player characters). (Shepherd 2024, np)

This article shows three things: first, the *Age of Nostalgia* that Bauman (2017) describes is still very present; second, nostalgia, defined as the “longing for a home that no longer exists or has never existed” (Boym 2001, xiii), can be separated from personally lived experience of the past; third, retro-gaming fosters popular, fragmentary, creative reappropriation of video games of the past. The second point already has been explored from a game design perspective, showing that “the psychological and aesthetic experience of nostalgia need not be tied to specific historical or stylistic references” (Sloan 2016, 13). The third point builds upon the concept of *creative nostalgia* which

reveals the fantasies of the age, and it is in those fantasies and potentialities that the future is born. One is nostalgic not for the past the way it was, but for the past the way it could have been. It is this past perfect that one strives to realize in the future. (Boym 2001, 351)

Retro gaming, in its creative practices, realises “the social potential of nostalgia [...] in its ability to direct a subjective experience toward a collective goal” (Srirachanikorn 2024, 40).

I divide my analysis of video game nostalgia into two parts: first, the video game experience as favouring nostalgia; second, retrogaming as a creative practice of nostalgia.

6.4.3.1. *The Experience of Video Game Nostalgia*

I want to start the genealogy of video game nostalgia with what is often considered the first video game (Kent et Molyneux 2001, 20): *Spacewar!* (Russel 1962), which illustrates on multiple degrees the specific role of video games regarding nostalgia and Empire. The birth of video games in a military context showcases the ambivalent, subversive role they play within and against Empire (Dyer-Witheford and de Peuter 2009, 6). *Spacewar!* is the product of a playful subversion in arguably the most serious workplace in the world. In the context of nostalgia, *Spacewar!* also poetically represents the players' victory in the Space Race. To demonstrate that, I need to redefine video games as 'homes that no longer exist or have never existed' and that are able "to capture the past as it was experienced once upon a time" (Bosman 2023, 37).

First, I situate nostalgia in the space of the imaginal, of the mythical space, for it is a way "in which we make sense of our seemingly ineffable homesickness" (Boym 2001, 41). Thus, the longed-for 'home' of nostalgia belongs to this same space between the actual and the imaginary. Throughout *La Poétique de l'Espace*, Bachelard (1957) develops the different possible ways to inhabit and to make sense of this space, from the house—the most concrete—to the circle—the most abstract. Although he does not use the term imaginal, or mythical, his descriptions are in the space of the daydream, which "deepens to the point where an immemorial domain opens up for the dreamer of a home beyond man's earliest memory" (Bachelard 2009, 5) and thus—at least partially—coincide with the mythical space.

Furthermore, the house, as a concretisation of home, "is one of the greatest powers of integration for the thoughts, memories and dreams of mankind. The binding principle in this integration is the daydream" (6). According to Bachelard, "the conscious metaphysics that starts from the moment when the being is cast into the world is a secondary metaphysics" (7), whereas the phenomenologist's perspective defines the house we were born in as primary (ibid.). The 'house we were born in' is described as "a sort of earthly paradise" (ibid.), it "is more than an embodiment of home, it is also an embodiment of dreams" (15).

Bachelard argues that the memory of the home's protective physicality is associated with longer-lasting oniric places of daydream:

[B]eyond all the positive values of protection, the house we were born in becomes imbued with dream values which remain after the house is gone. Centers of boredom, centers of solitude, centers of daydream group together to constitute the oneiric house which is more lasting than the scattered memories of our birthplace. (Bachelard 2009, 17)

When the house no longer physically exists, this house meaningfully persists more in the mythical space than in the actual memories (Bachelard 2009, 16).

In poetic nostalgia, some figures separate the nostalgia from themselves. In Chinese classic poetry, it is the moon (Shi and An 2021, 577); in pre-islamic poetry the “faded state of the abodes” (Khankan 2002, 23) which is similar to Western romantic poetry’s ruin (Boym 2001, 15); and in modern western poetry the turn back to nature (cf. Acquisto 2010). These symbols of lost home are unreachable, although physically present, and their nostalgic part exists through the words of the poets. A game, however, from Caillois’s definition ([1939] 1988), combines both the protective aspects (177) of the physical home *and* the meaningful and long-lasting aspects of the oneiric home (134). Games defined as such constitute privileged spaces to enter the realm of nostalgia; they constitute *homes that only exist in the mythical space*. Furthermore, video games, because they “share the capacity of other (digital or analogue) mediums like books or films to capture the past as it was experienced once upon a time” (Bosman 2023, 37), give the players the hope to find their ‘home’ as unchanged. To study this specific video game nostalgia, I propose to first summarise the history of retro-gaming and then examine creative reappropriation of retro-gaming—the contemporary nostalgic poets—especially through the case study of *Rétro découverte* (Edward 2016).

Nostalgia for video games

is not nostalgia for a past state before the trauma of the games disrupted us, but a desire to recapture that mind-altering experience of being in a game *for the first time*. ... *It is a yearning for liminality itself—for the moment of transition*. (Fenty 2008, 23; my emphasis)

The notion of ‘first time’ is essential to capturing the essence of video games as ‘home where we were born in’. Video games constitute a meaningful cluster that associates ‘first time’, transformation, loneliness, and nostalgia. Bachelard’s (2009) analysis of “*Fragments from an*

intimate diary that precede a French collection of Rilke's letters"¹³ (36), highlights that the memory of a first experience of a common phenomenon—in his case, the night—transforms the collective experience of such a phenomenon into a lonely one. On the other way around, loneliness can be considered a trigger for nostalgia, taken in the following causal relationship: “The lonelier one feels, the more nostalgic one becomes, and the more social support one may then perceive” (Zhou et al. 2008, 1024). The following paragraphs detail the phenomenological transformations that happen to the lonely player in front of her game, and that are necessary to play different kinds of video games and how, in conclusion, they make them special places for nostalgia.

Video games are characterised by being a *learning* space, as they need non-trivial effort to be travelled. Due to their learning curve, the “cold” aspect of video games pushes players outside of an immersive state toward an involved state (Fenty 2008, 28). The latter happens in the imaginal, mythical, daydream, as it asks players to focus on their actual body and experience to train and tame themselves to travel to the game’s world. This training constitutes a change in the player’s phenomenology. Using Klevjer’s (2022) example of “a radio-controlled model car” (98), players develop an awareness of the micro-topography of their environment when they are used to “navigating the environment via the extension of the model extending their perception” (ibid.).

The same awareness is developed through learning an avatar’s behaviour. A *Kaizo Mario* (Takemoto 2007) speedrunner learns the palette of movements available to her to read the game-level affordances for these movements. Fighting games are a salient example of this kind of learning as they can be seen as a mix between a game like chess, necessitating tactical planning (Sylvester 2012, 141), and jazz playing, necessitating intuitive decision making, the twitch decision (ibid.). A game can also facilitate learning to make profound decisions (ibid.) when its logic is too complex or obscure to rely on tactics and one must thus rely on emotional and cultural experience. Arguably, a game like *Papers Please* (Pope 2013), although it requires some kind of twitch and tactical decision-making, presents the player with ethical dilemmas which makes her learn about her own moral system as on the game’s. Finally, a game like *Dishonored* (Arkane Studio 2012), offers a world rich with different learnings. The player must learn how to move her avatar with basic movement and the Blink power, allowing her to

¹³ I could not find access to this text and thus ask the reader to only retain Bachelard’s analysis as meaningful for my argument.

instantly traverse a straight line in space; the different interactions she can have with the environment and enemies; and how her tools, powers, environment and different NPCs can interact with each other. Each mission of the game offers the player the choice between a lethal and a nonlethal approach to eliminate her target, which impacts the game's ending—the 'high chaos' ending when killing everyone and the 'low chaos' when sparing everyone. The consequence makes meaningful each encounter with an NPC, the choice to spare or kill an enemy, and, even more so, a mission target, impacts the identity of the avatar, the dialogues, the world, the number of enemies and the ending.

To reach electronic closure, which happens when “the map of the story [—and by extension, the map of the story world—] inside the head of the reader has become clear” (Murray 2017, 216), of such a complex game requires the player to rummage through the game's world multiple times to understand and observe all the possible consequences of all her possible actions. During that phase, the player does not only play the game but also plays *with* the game, experiments, and learns within the virtual space, making it a home. It is then possible for the player to associate with different areas of the game, and different moments of different forms of learning, making it as powerful as the daydream of a home. The game becomes a place of daydreaming, and thus a nostalgic place.

6.4.3.2. *Retrogaming.*

Video game nostalgia can also be detached from personal experiences made in the game. They are not necessarily a 'house where we were born in' but can be the symbol of nostalgia, namely in a retro aesthetic. This phenomenon is closely linked to Jameson's (1991) description of the postmodern era: the impossibility of identifying the present (296), and the detachment of the past from its original context.

The 'retro' in videogames concerns a practice, retrogaming, as well as an aesthetic, retro video games. Retrogaming “pertains to the use of retired hardware that is no longer being produced and no longer receives software support from the original manufacturer for gaming” (Thomasson 2014, 339). Retro video games are either “video and computer games published up to roughly the early 2000s” (Downing 2011, 751), or games that reproduce the aesthetic of older games

through self-imposed limitation in terms of colour palette, mechanics, and sound quality for example (Bosman 2023, 34). It is possible to tie retrogaming with the open source and hacking history that characterised the birth of video games (Coleman and Dyer-Witthford 2007, 934) but also with the necessity to preserve video games:

[O]n 5 February 1997 when Nicola Salmoria, inspired by the open source philosophy, released the first video game emulator. The software's professed *raison d'être* was "to document the hardware (and software) of the arcade games". (Payne 2008, 56)

This double role of the retrogaming community confronts technical and legal obstacles coming from the industrialisation of software development.

The conversion between source code and object code cannot be easily inverted, and this acts as an effective control over the use made of object code (for interpreted languages, the source code can be obfuscated, meaning that although it still runs, it is more difficult for a human to understand it). As a consequence, 'traditional' commoditised proprietary software has been distributed in object code form, rather than source code, rendering modification of the software difficult. (Walden 2022, 1)

Initially, software was free or shareware, distributed as open-source programs (Rajanen and Iivari 2013, 69). With this hacker culture also developed the sharing of games: "UNIX came with Find the Wumpus¹⁴ installed; Adventure debuted gratis on university computers; from Simsoc to Lunar Landing to Hammurabi, games circulated as freeware." (Downing 2011, 936). In the final report of the *Preserving Virtual Worlds* project (McDonough et al. 2011), intellectual property legislation counts among the obstacles "to the development of emulation technology necessary for continuing access to some games" (ibid. 6). Indeed, all the websites preserving old games, also called 'abandonware', that started appearing in the 1990s are illegal (Downing 2011, 940). Nowadays, most emulators, software that allows a "completely different and unrelated platform to operate its gaming software" (Thomasson 2014, 340), are legal as they are based on 'reverse engineering', considered fair use of copyrighted software in the two major legal cases involving emulation (cf. United States Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit 1992; 2000). Although they proliferate on the internet, ROM-sharing websites—to download game files—, are illegal. The only way to legally play a game on an emulator is to own a physical copy of that

¹⁴ The correct original name of the game is *Hunt the Wumpus* (Yob, 1973)

game and transfer it onto the computer. Why are game companies exerting legal pressure to own games that they do not sell anymore?

The commodification of retro gaming appeared in 2002 with the JAKKS Plug and Play machines (Fenty 2008, 58). They offered an easy way to play retro games without having to install an emulator or pirate games. In 2006, Nintendo launched the *Virtual Console*, a digital marketplace where a selection of old games are sold for reduced price, to be played on the Wii (Whalen and Taylor 2008, 1). In 2018, the *Virtual Console* evolved into Nintendo's subscription system, the *Nintendo Switch Online*, which offers emulators and a selection of games to play on the Nintendo Switch. These commodifications of retro games impact the collective memory of retro gamers. If emulators allow “free gamers to author their own narratives of gaming memory and catalyze the potential proliferation of multiple gaming histories and textual canons” (Fenty 2008, 56-57), commodified retro games impose a history of video games controlled by the industry.

In 2016 *Pokemon Uranium* (Involuntary Twitch 2016) and *AM2R* (Guasti 2016) were nominated in the “Best Fan Creation” category and then pulled from the Game Awards because of a Nintendo takedown notice (Imms 2016). The exposure of such games cannot rely on official or semi-official institutions. However, the speedrunning community does not hesitate to put out-of-canon games forward. For instance, *AM2R* was on the list of runned games in the 2025 edition of *SpeeDons*, a French video game speedrun charity marathon.

France is an exception in many regards concerning retro-gaming. It first proves wrong that “[n]ational libraries and archives do not currently have systematic strategies for collection and certainly not for preserving access and runtime functionality” (Pintchbeck et al. 2009, 1). Thanks to the obligation for digital legal deposit since 1992, the *Bibliothèque nationale de France*'s (BnF) video game collection counts more than 22,000 titles, according to their website (Bibliothèque nationale de France, n. d.). “However, in order to ensure the best possible preservation of media and to offset the gradual obsolescence of machines and operating systems, BnF favours access to games by emulation” (ibid., n.p.; my translation). Technical and legal limitations lamented in the papers mentioned above are thus already solved.

Practices of video games reached mainstream media in advance: the first ‘let’s play’, a recorded video of a video game with its player, appeared on the TV channel *Game One*, in a broadcast

called *Level One* in 1998 (Streiff and Vincent 2024). With more developed writing than the ‘let’s play’ format, a popular multidisciplinary approach to video games appeared on the website *Jeuxvideo.com*. Between 2011 and 2016 multiple series of videos analysed movies related to video games, video game music, technical processes used in the making of video games, and the history of video games. Most of them ended because of the new managerial direction after the acquisition of *Jeuxvideo.com* by Webedia (Coquaz 2015a; 2015b). The following paragraphs focus on *Retro Découverte* (Edward 2016) a web series that started on *Jeuxvideo.com* and continued its way on Youtube with 241 episodes at present.

Retro Découverte’s initial goal was to make its audience discover obscure games from the past. Over the years, the series developed to include more characters, intrigues, and interviews of developers, with its last crowdfunded season reaching over 160,000 euros on Ulule (Valdoise Images 2023), and its most popular video 1.2 million views on Youtube (Edward 2020). The series accurately explores the themes of video game nostalgia and retrogaming through complex narrative devices. Within *Retro Découverte*, ideas of multiplicity, situatedness and fluidity are very present. One of the main topics is the multiplicity of the gaming experience. The fictional, but realistic, settings of the videos play a role as important as the historical information given in the episodes, making the player’s experience central to the meaning of a game. *Retro Découverte*’s characters function as prisms through which a game can develop its multiplicity of meanings, depending on their experience with games in general or with a specific game. For instance, a character who usually never plays video games gives insights on the game that are usually never present in traditional game reviews and ‘let’s plays’.

Retro Découverte’s episodes can take the form of flashbacks, in which Edward fictionally re-situates the play experience at the game’s date of publication and during childhood. These episodes attempt to capture the “first-time” characteristic of video game nostalgia. In episodes happening in the present time, the characters are aware that they are filming a *Retro Découverte* episode. Edward’s YouTube channel can thus be placed on the same ontological level as alternate reality games (ARG), where the medium is part of the fiction, placing the ontological border one step above usual YouTube videos. Edward cleverly plays with this ambiguity when, in one episode (, he mentions to the character that he already set up a camera to shoot the episode: instead of pointing the camera and showing it on screen, the audience is shown the perspective of

the camera with the character looking at it—and for the audience, looking at them (2024a, 00:07:16). Edward also includes his audience through a compilation of fan-made short videos telling about their gaming memories (2024b). In the same direction, he narrativises his experience at a retrogaming convention where he met some of his fans (2024c).

The web series can thus be understood through and itself expresses fluidity, situatedness and multiplicity on multiple levels. Although it is limited in budget, this kind of production contributes on a small scale to the tradition of nostalgic poets but also, because of their reflective historical value, to one of scribes and myth writers. As such, there are reasons to believe that *Retro Découverte* should become a key piece of media for the understanding of the contemporary ‘*Age of Nostalgia*’.

Game Prototype

1. Design Idea:

Throughout my thesis, the main reflection about games and players is a reflection on space and travel. If academic writing required me to find the right theories, the creation of a game requires finding the right metaphors, the right images, the right representation and configuration of the game world. Bachelard's *La poétique de l'espace* (1957), is the main sourcebook for doing this translation, to tell in a verse what metaphysics explains in a book. The other requirement that I had to keep during the design process is that my game should foster reflection during gameplay; it should be a deformed mirror of the player. In other words, I have to make the player believe that the 'You' is her actual Self, which evidently cannot be, and then deceive them. The more the operation is repeated, the more the player should develop a sense of reflection through playing. I had to find a mobile space for a solitary reflection. The submarine fulfils that role in many regards. It is both the protective home seen in Chapter 6, and a way to travel as seen in Chapter 5. It is a vicarious body where Dovey and Kennedy's (2006) "cyborg *at the machine*" (110) and "cyborg *in the machine*" (111) are inverted: the human *in* the submarine is *at* the machine, composing a reflection of the player as a cyborg.

As mentioned in the introduction, there are two borders to my ontological explanation, an inside and an outside Zero—theoretically defined as irony and metaphysics—that can only be explored through artistic rather than scientific expression. My design must thus make the player reflect both on the infinity of the inside and of the outside and how they relate to each other in an existential horror: "fear is here the being itself" (Bachelard [1957] 1961, 196). The labyrinth structure of the first level offers the player time to be lost, i.e., to wander and wonder *in* the submarine. More than creating a disorienting experience, the labyrinth is also designed so the player does not know whether she is entering or exiting it; *The Submarine* is both outside and inside the submarine.

The choice of the submarine rather than a spaceship—which would fulfill the roles mentioned above—is made because of the substance surrounding the vessel: “To look for up, down, right or left in a world so unified by its substance, is to think, not to live—it is to think as once in earthly life, not to live in the new world conquered by diving” (Bachelard [1957] 1961, 186). Opposed to space as a view from nowhere, the depths of the ocean offer a view from within a single substance that constitutes everything around the submarine; the view from the submarine is a view from everywhere.

The last element of space design is the threshold between the inside and the outside, which requires finding simple ludic elements of liminality. I chose doors to be the main points of orientation for the player. “How concrete everything becomes in the world of a soul when an object, when a simple doorway gives the images of hesitation, temptation, desire, security, welcome, respect” (Bachelard [1957] 1961, 201)! Still, because my thesis focuses on liminality itself, the codes that the player can find throughout the games are not codes to open the doors, but the doors themselves: the key to knowledge is to find a new door.

2. Technical documentation:

The Submarine is a narrative game developed on Twine and hosted on my website <https://chrabz.github.io>.

1. Intended game walkthrough:

- The three doors puzzle room gives access to Door 423.
- Room 423 gives the right time to enter the room with the roses.
- Listening to the *Lincolnshire Poacher* gives access to Door 39715.
- Room 39715 points the player towards the YouTube video.
- The video’s commentary gives access to a new dialogue option with the dev in Room 423 and provides hints to the player that she should use the window multiple times before escaping.
- This allows players to ‘Feel alive’ when watching the corridor go by, unlocking access to the Submarine (Level 2).

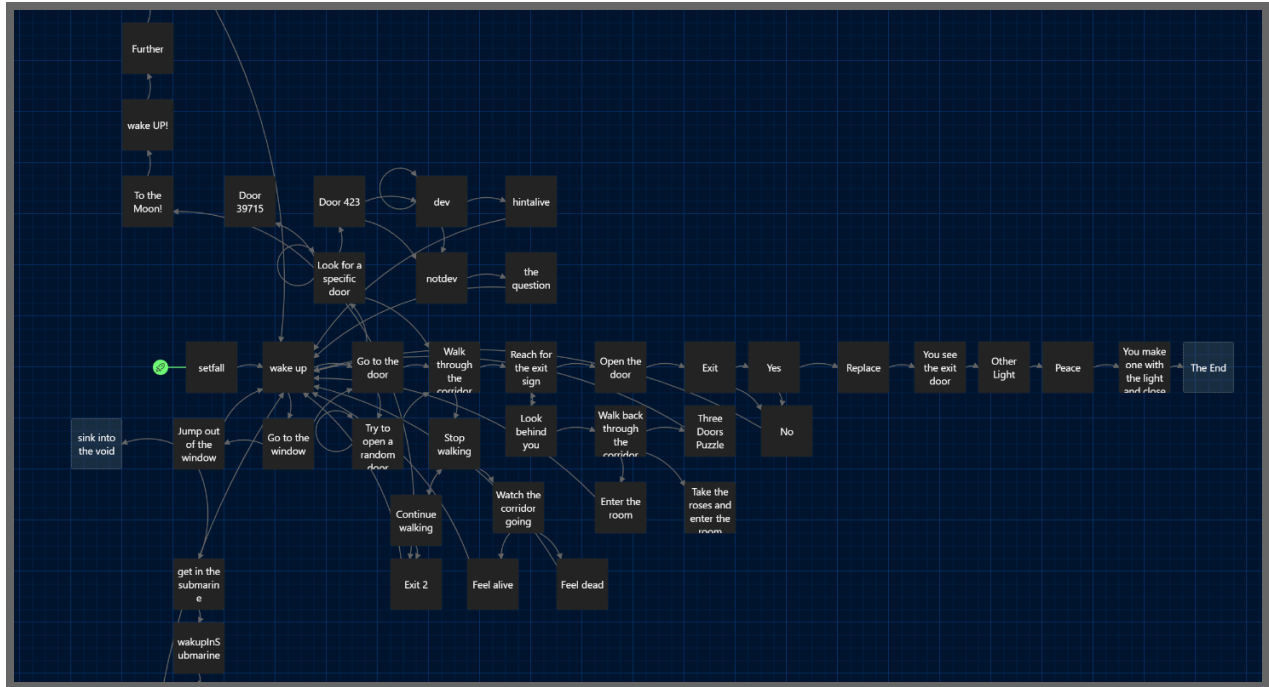
- Finishing Level 2 unlocks Door 333, leading to Level 3.
- The Game ends at the end of Level 3.
- Multiple other endings can be found throughout gameplay:
 - Ending 0: ‘Jump out of the window’ and sink into the void
 - Ending 1: Replace a character waiting to exit the simulation. The narrator’s and player’s places are inverted as such:

You can see a light on the horizon. Everything else is pitch black
Go to the light
Sink in the void

Screenshot of Ending 1. The descriptive text in blue is interactive, while the interaction options, in white, are not clickable.

- Ending 2: By entering the *Lost* code and finding ‘Exit 2’ with the text “You broke it”.
- Ending 3: Towards the end of Level 2, it is possible to play Ending 1 as the character waiting and not as the narrator.

The Twine boxes are organised to remind the observer of a submarine shape. The second level goes downwards, and the third level upwards:



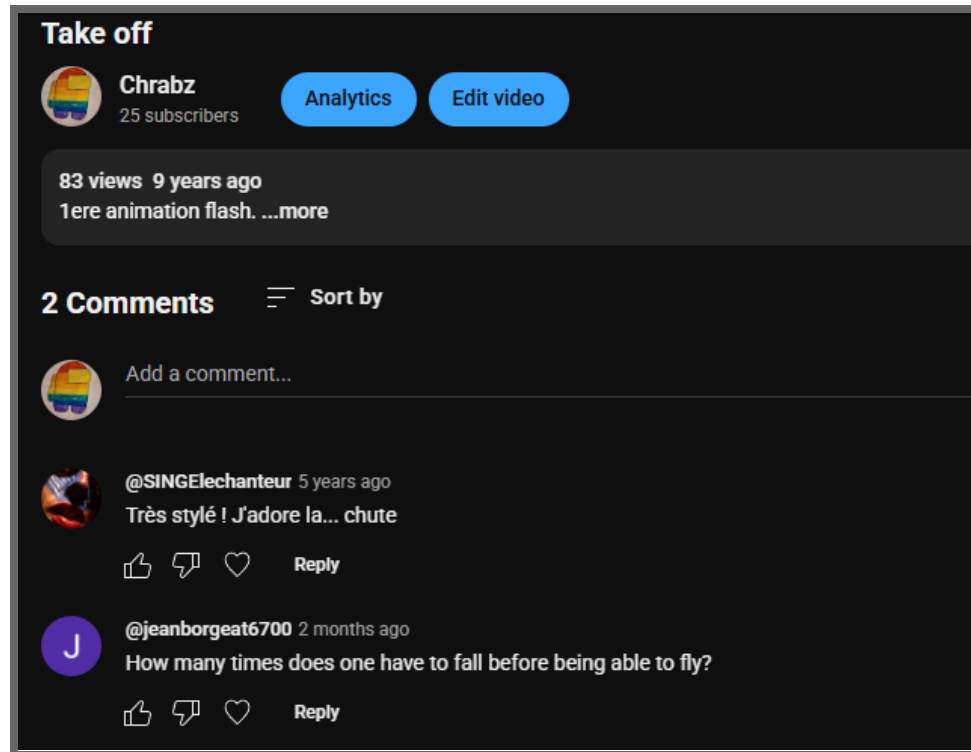
Screenshot of the Twine project. The nodes of the story form a submarine shape.

2. Narrative Themes:

- The three levels of the game explore time as:
 - Cyclical: restarting multiple times in the same room.
 - Eschatological: finding endings.
 - Linear: players progress through levels.
- Meaning and suicide
- Dissociation

3. Use of External Media:

- I included a link to an old Flash animation I made. Players are hinted to go there by 'the dev' in one of the game's rooms.
- I created the Google account @jeanborgeat6700, which serves as a necessary clue for the game's progression.



Screenshot of the YouTube video's commentary section. Both Chrabz and jeanborgeat6700 are my Google accounts.

4. Programming-related Devices

4.1. The Countdown:

- The countdown is initially set as such:

```
(set: $counter to 97)
|amount>[$counter]
(live: 1s)[(set: $counter to it -1)
(if: $counter is 0)[(go-to: "wake up")]
(replace: ?amount)[$counter]]
```

Template for the countdown's code.

- Copied in every room, its speed and effects can be changed easily:
 - To give hints for a puzzle:


```
(set: $counter to 97)
|amount> [$counter]
(live: 1s)[(set: $counter to it -1)
(if: $counter < 80) [Dawn, Noon, and Night]
(if: $counter < 60) [What did the Sphinx Ask?]
(if: $counter is 0)[(go-to: "wake up")]
(replace: ?amount)[$counter]]
```

The first hint appears when the countdown reaches 80, and the second when it reaches 60.

- To go backwards in time:

```
|amount> [$counter]
(live: 1s)[(set: $counter to it +1)
(replace: ?amount)[$counter]]
```

The '-1' from the template is changed into a '+1'

- In the following example, it serves only as a condition to activate an audio file necessary for the game's progression. The player needs to enter the room with the counter set on 106:

```
(if: $counter is not 106) [You are not supposed to be here now.
Close the game please.]

(if: $counter is 106) [The radio is on. <audio
src="https://chrabz.github.io/submarine/submarinemusic/lincoln.mp3" autoplay>]
```

The code represents the two possible versions of a room that depend on the countdown.

- To control access to particular rooms:

```

[amount>[$counter]
(live: 0.1s)[(set: $counter to it -1)
(if: $counter is 0 and $memory1)[[Feel alive]]
(if: $counter is 0) [[Feel dead]]
(if: $counter is 0)[(stop:)]
(replace: ?amount)[$counter]]

```

The rooms 'Feel alive' and 'Feel dead' are only accessible if the countdown reaches zero.

- Here, it shows a series of numbers for players to remember:

```

(set: _t to 0)
[amount>[$counter]
(live: 0.3s)[
(set: _t to it+1)
(set: $counter to (nth: _t, 4, 8, 15, 16, 23, 42))
(replace: ?amount)[$counter]]

```

The code makes it so the countdown cycles through the series of numbers from Lost, changing the number every 0.3 seconds.

4.2. The three doors puzzle:

Every *link-rerun* function serves as a button with conditions for its appearance and allows players to take and put roses in front of the doors to solve the puzzle:

```
|status>[
{
  (if: $rosefirst is 4 and $rosesecond is 2 and $rosethird is 3)[
    [[wake up]]
  ]
  (else:)[
    (if: $rosesleft is 1)[There is one rose left] (if: $rosesleft is 0)[No roses are left] (if: $rosesleft > 1)[There are $rosesleft roses left]

    (if: $rosefirst > 1)[There are [$rosefirst] roses in front of the first door] (if: $rosefirst < 2)[There is [$rosefirst] rose in front of the first door]
    (if: $rosesecond > 1)[There are [$rosesecond] roses in front of the second door] (if: $rosesecond < 2)[There is [$rosesecond] rose in front of the second door]
    (if: $rosethird > 1)[There are [$rosethird] roses in front of the third door] (if: $rosethird < 2)[There is [$rosethird] rose in front of the third door]

    (if: $rosesleft is not 0)[
      (link-rerun: "Put a rose in front of the first door")[(set: $rosefirst to $rosefirst+1) (set: $rosesleft to $rosesleft-1) (rerun: ?status)]
      (link-rerun: "Put a rose in front of the second door")[(set: $rosesecond to $rosesecond+1) (set: $rosesleft to $rosesleft-1) (rerun: ?status)]
      (link-rerun: "Put a rose in front of the third door")[(set: $rosethird to $rosethird+1) (set: $rosesleft to $rosesleft-1) (rerun: ?status)]
    ]

    (if: $rosefirst > 0)[(link-rerun: "Take a rose in front of the first door")[(set: $rosefirst to $rosefirst-1) (set: $rosesleft to $rosesleft+1) (rerun: ?status)]]
    (if: $rosesecond > 0)[(link-rerun: "Take a rose in front of the second door")[(set: $rosesecond to $rosesecond-1) (set: $rosesleft to $rosesleft+1) (rerun: ?status)]]
    (if: $rosethird > 0)[(link-rerun: "Take a rose in front of the third door")[(set: $rosethird to $rosethird-1) (set: $rosesleft to $rosesleft+1) (rerun: ?status)]]
  ]
}]
```

The code is organised as such: first it states the condition for solving the puzzle; second it checks the position and count of roses; third, it checks which options are available to the player after her choice.

4.3. Dialogues with Body, Meaning and Journal:

Each character is separated and unlocks dialogue options for other characters. For example, it is necessary to complete the dialogue with Meaning to unlock the one with the Journal:

```
[1> [(text-colour:red)[Body]
(if: $body1 is 0)[
(link:"Listen")+(text-colour:red)[Even if you don't listen to me I listen to you
(link:"Stop Listening")+(text-colour:red)[(set: $body1 to 1) (rerun:?1)]]]
(if: $body1 is 1)[
(text-colour:red)[Rude...]
(link:"What do you hear?")+(text-colour:red)[You have to act to know that
(link:"Act")[[[Follow me|Act2]]]]]

[2> [(text-colour:cyan)[Meaning]
(link:"Ask")+(text-colour:cyan)[It is only a shell, but it is all one has
(link:"Answer")+(text-colour:cyan)[Seek the mysteries inside
(link:"Wonder")[(set: $meaning1 to 1)(rerun:?3)(rerun:?2)]]]

[3> [(text-colour:lime)[Journal]
(if: $meaning1 is 1)[
(link:"Write")+(text-colour:lime)[There is a new message from the outside world:
(link:"Read")+(text-colour:lime)[Code 423: Jean Borgeat's mental state is critical. Request the submarine to start ascent
(link:"Close Journal")[(set: $journal1 to 1)(rerun:?3)]]]
]
(if: $journal1 is 1)[
(link:"Write")+(text-colour:lime)[I need to get to the command room for an emergency situation 423
(link:"Read")+(text-colour:lime)[Yes and maybe add "Captain Picard's logbook" and don't forget to activate the hyperspace...
(link:"Close Journal")[(set: $journal1 to 1)(rerun:?3)]]]
]
]
```

The code is organised with one logic loop per character. Each dialogue option updates the status of the other characters with the 'rerun:' command.

3. Analysis

The Submarine is divided into three different levels. Unlike academic writing, the game does not need to be rational and can thus successfully explore the invisible parts of my master's thesis. Time is the central component of the game. As explored in Chapter 5, *The Submarine* is about different conceptions of time that manifest in the mechanics of the game as well as the narrative. For example, one of the clues necessary for the game's progression requires the player to find a screen where time flows backwards and to enter a room at a precise time displayed there. On the narrative level, *The Submarine* hints at a mythology behind its creation involving the story of three protagonists searching for a true conception of time, to determine if it is cyclical, eschatological, or linear and infinite.

While the main play time is to be spent on the first level, the other two levels bring forward other approaches to the same object. The second level is a deep dive into the submarine; metaphorically, this means that the depth of fictionality can only be reached if one plunges into a tunnel. The player cannot choose between different narrative branches but only go forward without time or space operations. This level makes players feel most at ease with the game world: there is a character, dialogue, as well as a goal, and the lack of understanding associated with the first level is cleared up by the 'it was all a dream' trope. The fantastic elements in this level, i.e., the dialogue with Body, Meaning and Journal, are more readily acceptable, being a step down in terms of unnaturalness. This allows the player to hold on to what feels more real than the first part of the game, to fix and stabilise meaning with a new referent in the main character's waking world. In this way, the various number combinations are found in this fictional waking world, until the character is forced to go back to sleep.

The game is a variation on the Butterfly's Dream theme, with the player waking up in a dream, so that dreaming and waking become two sides of the same coin. The dreaming of the submarine gives the player the chance to discover the third level, i.e., distancing themselves from the game itself. This distance is already prepared by the other rooms behind the code doors, which allow the player to communicate with the game's so-called 'designer' and its website, and even to read a commentary under a YouTube video external to the site, yet included in the game. In the third

level, the player is asked to fully assume that the game is self-aware by showing parts of its code and overall structure through screenshots of the game engine.

This concern for honesty towards players is perhaps what brings the game closest to my master's thesis, i.e., the desire to always place the game in a *context*. What the player is surprised by, and what the player learns, is not hidden by *The Submarine*; all the elements are made accessible as the game progresses until the machine behind the experience is revealed. I do not know anything more about my own game than what I freely give to the player.

The overall ambience of the game is carefully crafted to be more on the uncanny side of liminal affects. In the first level, cultural references are drawn from ARG culture, a form of horror that plays with the pervasion of fiction into reality. For example, the series *Lost* (Lieber, Abrams and Lindelof 2004)—referenced in *The Submarine* through its iconic number sequence—had its fair share of fake adverts and websites promising players clues about the next part of the series. Another reference, the *Lincolnshire Poacher*, comes from the actual world's number stations, radio traces of coded messages from the Cold War that leave room for the imagination and research work of the radio and internet communities to mythologise them. These two examples work because players are convinced that the numbers must have meaning and that they can be explained by understanding the intentions of the higher entities that emit and determine these messages. It is the hope of meaning that motivates players to seek out and invent stories from mysterious and incomprehensible objects.

Levels two and three take their inspiration from another universe, also linked to the loss of meaning and the fantastic. Firstly, there are the writings of *Antichamber* (Demruth 2013), which give a moral to the puzzles and require the player to take steps that run counter to Euclidean geometry and the intuitive logic of space as we experience it every day. The two mini-narratives before the start of the levels serve as transition where a glimpse of meaning, a minimal narrativisation is offered to the player. The second level is inspired by the dialogues in *Disco Elysium* (ZA/UM 2019) where the main character dissociates his entire identity from other, deeper parts of himself that make a mockery of him. The third level is similar to the end of *The Stanley Parable* (Galactic Cafe 2013) where the player is transported to a museum that explains the conception and design of the game itself. Through these aesthetic choices, the player is

pushed towards irony, forced to believe in the game even though she knows that this belief is false.

As a complement to my master's thesis theories, *The Submarine* provides an unsettling experience that phenomenologically connects its player to the virtually indescribable concepts of infinity, eternity, and nothingness, the irrational counterparts of space, time and truths. A playthrough of *The Submarine* is the *invisible* explanation of my thesis, a travel through its ontological gaps.

Conclusion

My master's thesis aims at creating a new definition of players by situating them in a theoretical framework primarily composed of narratology, phenomenology, and sociology. Through an extraction, deformation, and assemblage of concepts, I attempted to construct a meta-structure able to comprehend the ontological complexity implied by studying games, play, and players. Smaller-scale works and preexisting monodisciplinary theories can thus be analysed through my framework on multiple level: first, the players-Empire dichotomy is thought to be an intuitive step; second, the fluidity, situatedness, and multiplicity concepts should be applicable as a metaphorical step, i.e., the entrance to language; third, a relationship to concrete events should be made, taken as embodied experience, memory, or history; finally, the moral application of such a framework should guide the interpretation of concrete events. This last step implies knowledge about the context of production and that interpreters—i.e., writers and critical readers—are morally responsible for their interpretation in this context. Ultimately, my research led to the foundation of a groundwork for a Game Studies epistemology that goes beyond the small interest of games themselves to develop an agency in the ways Game Studies produce new knowledge about a culture's imaginary, experience, and institutions.

When deterritorialising different theories, it is necessary to find their original and new situation and to know the borders they cross along the way. The creation of the categories, the territorialisation, is first done through an observation of the borders, the liminal spaces themselves. Through a systematic observation of the spatial vocabulary of transdisciplinary research, it is possible to determine the doors and corridors, the liminal spaces between ontological realms. It resulted in the three questions: 'What makes a player exist in a game?', 'What makes this existence specific to games?', and 'What is the purpose of such an existence?', which respectively define the territory, the borders, and the morality of players. They thus exist in a material, meaningful and social way, in between fiction and institutions, with the hope that if fiction can transform them, they can transform institutions. From this territorial description of space, I develop a taxonomy of its substance that relies on the categories of *fluidity*, *situatedness*, and *multiplicity*.

I then succinctly define the field of studies that overlap with the spatial definition I established. Phenomenology, mainly defined through the theories of Maurice Merleau-Ponty, reveals itself as a solid method to *temporarily unify or annihilate all rational categories* to form new ones based on embodied experience. It can be considered a method to actualise and make meaningful scientific theories purely relying on rationality. Secondly, political philosophy and Durkheimian sociology are defined as both sides of the same coin, studying the *relationship between institutions and people*, the former focusing on the concept of power and the latter on social spaces. Thirdly, a range of theories studying metalepsis and make-believe are defined as the study of the space where fiction and people overlap. Finally, theories on myths and rituals encompass the fictional to the institutional realm through people's imagination and interactions, which can be understood as a narrativisation of the aforementioned phenomenological and sociopolitical theories.

Players belong to the mythical space, where the importance and transformative powers of fiction, expression and institutions are ambiguous. Players are mythological in the sense that their importance relies less on the kind of belief they foster than on the function they play in the narrative they are part of. They act as ontological travellers, implying both a transportation, a transformation and a double situation in and outside the game, for players are aware that they play a role, and they use this role as a vessel for existence. They are ironists because, while playing a role, they can both take it seriously and know that it is of lesser importance than the human behind that role.

To think of mythical spaces also allows for the multiplicity of temporalities implied by different narrativisations. The comparison between Empire and players is here the most interesting, because they both have narrativisation implying multiple temporalities at the same time, but do not play the same roles. Empire relies on the cyclical time to justify the reproduction of its institutions and injustice, and eschatological time to both justify the urgency of war to preserve its existence and the paradise on earth promised by its complete conquest. Empire's linear time only exists in the form of heroes of history, the important leaders who changed the course of time, justifying the authority of the emperor. Players perceive cyclical time in the temporary role they play in a game, eschatological time because games have an end, and linear time because they exist beyond games and are transformed by them.

A study of nostalgia connects all the themes studied in my thesis by linking space, time and truths, on different ontological layers, i.e. preserving an approach that is at once poetic, phenomenological and political, and that contrasts players and Empire. Nostalgia follows a particular trajectory in history. While the word was coined in Switzerland in the late 17th century in the context of medical science, its poetic notion as longing for home is much older, and can be found in a wide range of places in the world. I establish three definitions of nostalgia: the first is the medical definition, the Empire's vision as a disease to be cured in several contexts of military campaigns up to the 20th century; the second is the poetic definition, i.e. nostalgia as a form of utopia, as an affect that reflects and whose evolution is explained by political changes crossed with the history of neoliberalism; the third, video game nostalgia, comes close to this poetic definition, but the elsewhere is not only turned towards the past but also towards virtual worlds whose phenomenological implications differ from literature or cinema. Finally, the study of retrogaming as a product of nostalgia reveals an issue of control over collective memory, both through the preservation and representation of games and plays between players and the Empire.

A critical reading of my thesis highlights certain methodological, dialectical and historical shortcomings. The definition of a Game Studies epistemology, as I propose it, could be enriched by an in-depth study of more extensive epistemological projects such as those of Bachelard (1938) or Morin (2008). As indicated in the introduction, it is also necessary to confront players with their powerlessness in the face of the colonial question and concrete social action. The philosophical effectiveness of my work could also be refined by rigorous historical work on the evolution of Durkheimian sociology throughout the twentieth century, and by mythological work on the model of Barthes ([1957] 1961), which would constitute a series of player figures.

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